

[PowerliftingToWin](#) Presents:

# ProgrammingToWin

*by Izzy Narvaez*

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# PROGRAMMING TO WIN



**NOTICE!**

**Before embarking on any physical fitness program, consult your physician first.**

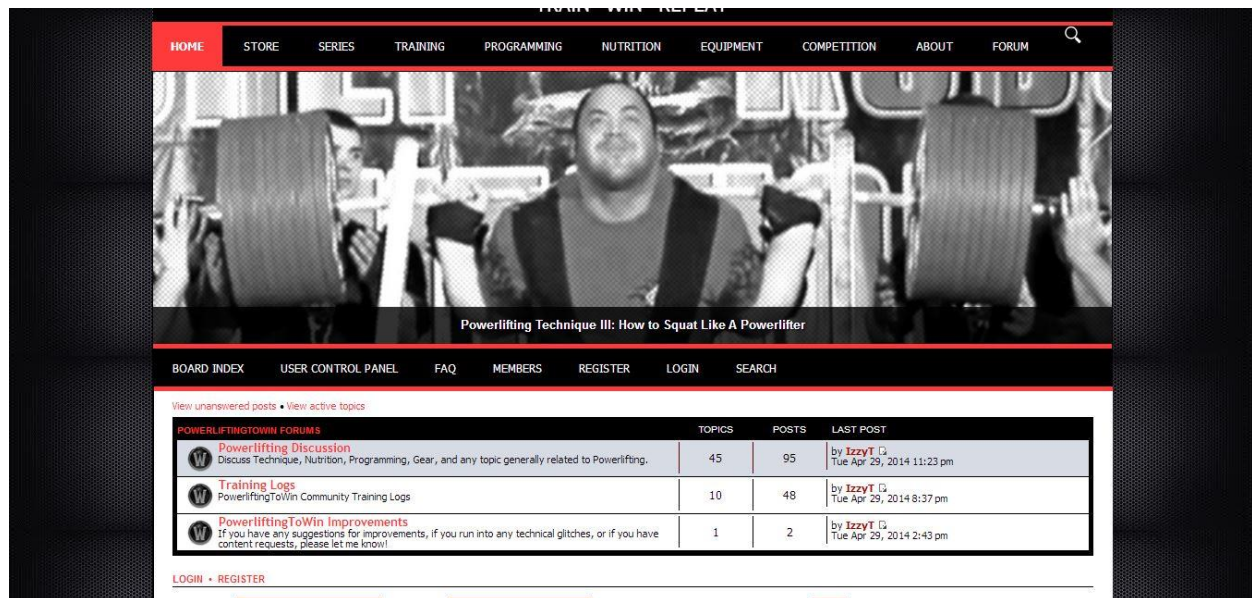
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## Foreword

### Thank You Forum Members!

This book would not have been possible without the contributions of the [PowerliftingToWin Forum](#) Members. I'd like to give an express thank you to all of the members who have diligently [logged their training on the PowerliftingToWin Novice Program](#). Your efforts allowed me to make further improvements and modifications to the original program. Your efforts allowed me to take **ProgrammingToWin** to another level.



The [PTW Forums](#) are now home to nearly 400 members.

### Optimal Training is Holistic

While I personally believe that any approach to powerlifting training that pretends to be optimal must be holistic in nature, please understand that this book is only going to cover [programming](#). Again, I personally believe that addressing [nutrition](#), [technique](#), psychology, supplementation, and a variety of other variables are absolutely mandatory in constructing a truly optimal plan for any individual. That said, this is not an all-encompassing resource.

### If You Want More than Programming...

If you'd like more information on the aforementioned topics, please visit [PowerliftingToWin.com](#). The content on [PowerliftingToWin.com](#) is of equal quality to what you'll find in this book. With everything I do, I endeavor to ensure it lives up to the [PowerliftingToWin](#) namesake. I believe you'll find that to be the case as well.

Alternatively, if you'd like a customized, personalized training package which covers programming, nutrition, technique, psychology and more, all specifically tailored to your personal needs, please [contact me for more information about my coaching services](#).

### Thank YOU for Your Time and Consideration

Finally, I'd like to thank you for downloading **ProgrammingToWin**. I have full faith that you will find the contents herein especially worthy of your time and consideration. As I have said elsewhere, [PowerliftingToWin](#)'s information is free and always will be. If you find this content to be of particular value to you personally, please consider making a [donation](#) to support the continued of [PowerliftingToWin](#).



I believe in freedom of information and I believe in the goodness of people. As such, I trust that those of you who are in a position to make a contribution will do so if you find the material worthy.

Likewise, I am incredibly happy that those of you who are not in a position to make a contribution can still enjoy this content freely. I take great pride in that fact. If you can't show monetary support, but you'd still like to show your appreciation for my work, please consider sharing this information with your lifting friends. I cannot overstate the enormous impact that [Facebook](#) shares, [forum posts](#), and the [YouTube](#) community at large have had on the growth and success of [PowerliftingToWin](#). Without all of your social media love, this project would have died a long time ago. If you want to see it keep going, sharing the information with as many people as possible is even more valuable for the survival of [PowerliftingToWin](#) than a donation. Of course, any support you show is deeply appreciated!

### What Up YouTube!?

I just want to give a special shout out to the [YouTube Fitness Community](#)! I mean, there isn't anything in particular I want to say, but you guys are just awesome in general. Thank you for the amazing positivity; thank you for spreading [PowerliftingToWin](#) content all across the net; and, thank you making all of this possible! Without YouTube, [PowerliftingToWin](#) would be DEAD. That's no exaggeration. That's a fact.



[Long live the Tubes!](#)

*Have a nice day my friends,*

**Izzy Narvaez**

[www.PowerliftingToWin.com](http://www.PowerliftingToWin.com)

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## Chapter 1: Introduction

### About PowerliftingToWin

#### PowerliftingToWin Is A Movement

**PowerliftingToWin** is a rebellion against the idea that maximal strength at all costs is the entire point of the sport of powerlifting. The point of any sport is competition. Competition exists to determine who the best athlete truly is. While strength is the largest component of what determines the best powerlifter, it is not the only component.

#### Powerlifting and Stereotypes

Far too often the average bystander conflates powerlifting with tremendously huge, tremendously fat men who both wear gear, including strange squat suits and bench shirts, and who take gear including anabolic steroids, growth hormone, and a variety of other performance enhancing drugs. While this is certainly one form of powerlifting, and an attractive form to many people, far too often the average bystander isn't aware of the myriad of competitive options that powerlifting offers.

The reality of the situation is that the world's largest powerlifting organization is the [International Powerlifting Federation](#) (IPF). The IPF has nearly 100,000 member athletes. Of more importance, the IPF is a drug-free organization that supports a large deal of "raw" lifters (those who train without special suits and shirts). Unbeknownst to many, these natural, raw lifters are tremendous athletes who are, for the most part, healthy, strong, and relatively lean. You don't have to be fat or take drugs to participate in powerlifting.



Photo: [www.powerlifting-ipf.com](http://www.powerlifting-ipf.com)

#### Meaningful Powerlifting Competition

Not only that, but the IPF is the only organization in the world that consistently offers meaningful competition across all genders and age groups. That's right: the IPF supports the sport's largest, by far, women's and master's divisions. Anybody of any age, race, creed, or sex can compete for meaningful national and world championships in the IPF.

In fact, the IPF was recently invited to partake in the World Games in 2008. This offered athletes the opportunity to win Gold medals for their country – an experience simply unavailable to any other

organization or any other type of powerlifter. Further still, the IPF hosts a World Championship every single year. IPF World's is the only legitimate, unified world championship in the sport of powerlifting today. While the contest allows only drug-tested lifters, there is virtually no argument in the powerlifting community as to whom the best drug-tested, raw lifters are: they are the IPF World Champions. Every other form of powerlifting is so splintered and scattered that you'll never get to see the best athletes go head to head.



Mike Tuchscherer brings home the gold for the USA!  
Photo: [jtsstrength.com](http://jtsstrength.com)

What's my point in all of this? [PowerliftingToWin](#) exists to promote the sport as a real sport and not merely as a gimmick to show off maximal strength. With the IPF, YOU, regardless of your demographics, have the opportunity to win a gold medal in a meaningful world championship. With the IPF, YOU, regardless of your demographics, can set meaningful state, national, and world records. With the IPF, YOU, regardless of your demographics, have access to serious competition to test your mettle as an athlete.

### **This Book Is For Athletes**

And that is exactly the idea that [PowerliftingToWin](#) promotes: powerlifters are athletes. As such, the information presented in the following book will be coming from a frame of reference that targets athletes who are doing their best to compete and win. Even if you choose to compete outside of the IPF, and regardless of whether you are currently competitive at a local level, state level, regional level, national level, or even international level, [PowerliftingToWin](#) is about providing strategies and practices that maximize your opportunities for success as an athlete. [PowerliftingToWin](#) is not about getting huge or maximizing your strength at all costs; [PowerliftingToWin](#) is about... powerlifting... to... win. You are an athlete and this resource is dedicated to helping you improve as much as is possible at the actual sport of powerlifting.

*IPF World's:*



Here Randy Zhou (left), Brett Gibbs (middle), and Jonnie Candito (right) represent the 83kg Juniors at IPF World's.  
Photo: Courtesy of [Jonnie Candito](#)

## Getting Started with Competition

To find out more about the IPF, [visit their website](#). If you'd like information on finding a powerlifting meet near you, [PowerliftingWatch](#) is a fantastic resource.

## Introducing ProgrammingToWin

### What is ProgrammingToWin?

**ProgrammingToWin** is the first installment of what will be the PowerliftingToWin Handbook. In this first edition, we'll be taking a look at what I believe to be the optimal programmatic strategy for your first two or three years in the sport.

Specifically, you'll be provided a step-by-step framework for how to set-up your program all the way from the true beginner level to the early stages of advanced training. In other words, both the entire novice and the entire intermediate phase of your training will be discussed. Specific programs will be provided at each and every turn.

As intimated in the introduction and other preceding text, my primary aim with this guide is to provide new lifters with a solid foundation of [programming theory](#) as well as practical, applicable training programs for their first two years in the sport. Our goal is get you to the highest competitive level possible with the greatest expediency manageable. Simply put, I want you to avoid the mistakes that I've made personally as well as what I've seen with my previous clients, training partners, and lifting acquaintances.

## About the Author

### My Background

[For those who aren't already somewhat familiar with me](#), my name is Izzy Narvaez. I have been actively competing in Powerlifting for three years. [My best lifts in competition](#) are a 551lbs/250kg squat, a 320lbs/145kg bench, and a 535lbs/242.5kg deadlift. I am a certified Starting Strength Coach and I have worked with more than three dozen novices on that particular program. I have also owned my own gym for a year.

*Izzy's Squat PR:*



**Izzy Squats 551lbs/250kg**

### **My Experience**

In my time working with novices, out of the dozens who didn't quit early on, only one male failed to reach a 315lbs/142.5kg squat in the first three months of training. Likewise, after six months of training, only one of our male novices failed to squat 405lbs/185kg or more. In fact, some trainees are squatting those weights for reps after that time. I do not say this to impress you, because these are fairly typical results for young males, but rather to impress upon you that the information I am going to provide for novice and early intermediate trainees comes from a rich history of getting results in the populations we will be focusing on in this book.

## Chapter 2: The Scientific Fundamentals of Powerlifting Programming

### Programming Introduction

#### Read This Section!

Many of you are going to be tempted to skip over this part of the book. You're going to want to get straight into the programs. I know this. However, I'd strongly recommend against doing so for the following reason: unless you know not only *why* what you're doing works, but *why* you should consider it "better" than other programs, you are unlikely to fully "buy-in" to the program. As a result, you're not only less likely to give your full effort, but you're leaving yourself susceptible to the dreaded program hopping disease. Don't be that guy.

#### Good, Better, Best

One of the most frequently asked programming questions on the internet is whether or not certain programs are "good" or "bad". The reality is that this is the wrong reference point from which to approach the subject of program evaluation. Most programs work. Some just work better than others. For example, we could take a true novice and get them to increase their 1RM on the squat by having them ride an exercise bike with a high resistance setting or, alternatively, we could take them to the squat rack and have them do sets of 3-5 reps. Both will work, but one strategy works quite a bit better than the other.

A better frame of reference was provided by Dr. Fred Hatfield and it is that of the "good, better, best" continuum. It isn't that, say, [5/3/1](#) is "bad" and [Sheiko](#) is "good"; thousands of trainees have made outstanding gains on both programs. The real questions we want to ask are which program is better and why is it better?



Famous Powerlifting Coach Boris Sheiko delivers a lecture.

## The True Purpose of Powerlifting Programs

For the purposes of powerlifting, these questions are both incredibly simple and relatively complex. In order to evaluate whether a program is superior or inferior to another, we need to know what purpose the program is intending to meet in the first place. While aesthetics, speed, athleticism, size, and general strength are worthy goals, they are not the primary concerns of a powerlifter.

*A powerlifting program exists to do exactly one thing: improve competition results.* Let me reiterate that point so that it may sink in: **the SOLE PURPOSE of a powerlifting program is to improve your total at a powerlifting meet.** Now, we may also improve our aesthetics, speed, muscle mass and other qualities along the way, but those benefits will be peripheral to the central goal of becoming better powerlifters.



THIS is the point of a Powerlifting Program!  
photo: [www.powerlifting-ipf.com](http://www.powerlifting-ipf.com)

With the understanding in place that our general purpose for any powerlifting program we partake in is to improve our total in a meet, we can now begin to look at the underlying fundamentals that are most responsible for improvements on the platform.

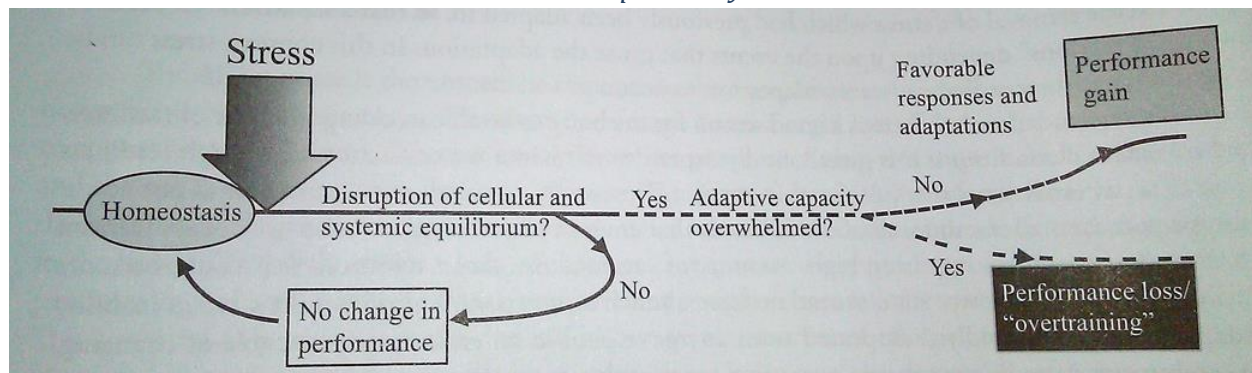
First, however, we need to understand why training itself works in the first place.

## The General Adaptation Syndrome

### Stress, Recovery, Adaptation

In explaining the process by which training makes us stronger, most of the currently popular theories revolve around Hans Seyle's theory of the General Adaptation Syndrome (GAS). GAS, in training terms, works through a process that can roughly be described as: stress → recovery → adaptation.

### *The General Adaptation Syndrome:*



Stress—>Recovery—>Adaptation.

Photo: [Practical Programming](#) 3rd Edition, Mark Rippetoe, Aasgaard Co. 2014.

Stress, the first stage of the process, literally represents a threat to the body; stress is a stimulus which disrupts homeostasis and prompts an adaptation.

For example, consider a pale, white individual who goes into the sun for the first time in a long time. The exposure actually causes microlevel damage to the skin (“stress”). Once removed from the stress, in time, the body not only repairs the damage (“recovery”), but the body also responds with a highly coveted (by some) defense mechanism against further damage: a tan (“adaptation”). However, keep in mind that you can actually die from overexposure and burning. This is why the body treats the stimulus as a “stress” in the first place – it is harmful.

### **Weight Training and GAS**

Now, for most, it should be fairly easy to see how this is analogous to training. When you go into the weight room and lift challenging weights, you cause microtears to muscle fibers and elicit a whole variety of hormonal responses which signal the body that “stress” has occurred. By eating and sleeping, we give the body time to “recover”. In order to prevent ourselves from undergoing the same “stress” next time we are exposed to the same stimulus, our body “adapts” by building up our muscles bigger and stronger (among a myriad of other adaptations caused by training). Again, keep in mind that if you do too much, you’ll overwhelm your adaptive capacity and “overtrain”, but more on that later.

## **Specificity**

### **To Lift Heavy, You Must Lift Heavy**

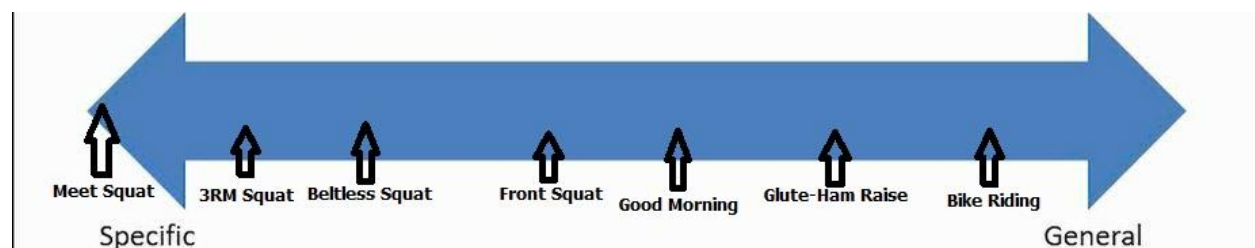
Now, it is crucial that you keep in mind that the GAS is only going to work in our favor for powerlifting if the stress we place on the body causes adaptations that are specific to improving powerlifting performance. We might be able to improve our mile time tremendously through proper manipulation of the GAS, but that doesn’t mean it will do anything for our powerlifting performance.

This may come as a shock to some of you, but in order to optimize the response we get from training, our training needs to be specific to our objectives. In simple terms, if you're engaging in a program that doesn't call for frequent squatting, benching, and deadlifting, your program might not be specific enough for powerlifting to maximize gains. If you are engaging in a program that doesn't call for the frequent use of heavy weights and higher percentages of your one rep max, your program might not be specific enough for powerlifting. Yes, that means *you should train on an actual powerlifting program – not a “general strength” program*. They are two different things.

Specificity is a whole concept unto itself. You could do literally everything else perfectly in your program, but if your training isn't specific to your sport, it doesn't matter. Even if you get the sets, reps, and weights just right, if you're doing a program designed for long distance runners, you shouldn't expect to be a good powerlifter.

### The Specificity Continuum

Specificity exists along a continuum. For example, it is rather obvious that swimming is unlikely to do much to increase your one rep max squat. However, a barbell exercise such as the Good Morning might have some considerable transference (carry over towards improvement). Further still, a beltless squat is going to have even higher rates of transference. And yet even further, we know that improving our one rep max competition form squat is going to yield perfect transference. On the other hand, increasing our five rep max, ten rep max, and twenty rep max on the competition form squat is going to produce significantly diminishing returns, respectively.



Now, of course, I am not saying that there is no place for variety in the training of a powerlifter, but one must be cognizant of the fact that specificity reigns supreme. If you want to make the best improvements possible to your powerlifting performance, the vast majority of your training needs to be composed of doing heavy lifting with the competition movements or close variations thereof. The further you move away from the specific end of the continuum, the higher your risk is for significantly diminished rates of transference from your training.

Correctly picking specialized movements designed to attack your particular movement weaknesses is one of the most difficult things that you can do in programming. If you're not well versed in exercise selection, you may end up selecting something with virtually no transference and wasting your time. If

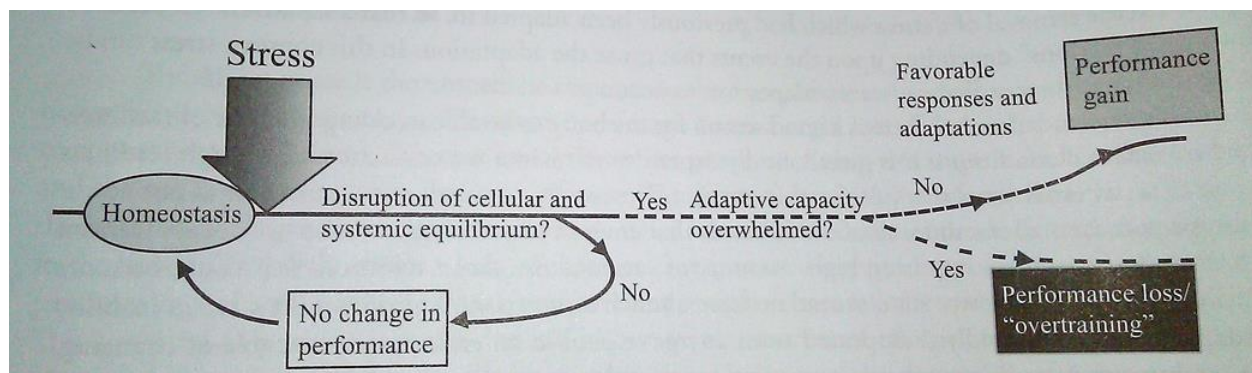
this describes you, and you'd like help personalizing your program with exercise selection, [consider contacting a coach](#).

## Overload

### Do More to Do More

Like specificity, improvement in powerlifting is not possible without continuous progressive overload. Look, the GAS cannot continue to work in our favor unless we provide the body with a stress that is significant enough to disrupt homeostasis. That simply will not occur if you repeat the same reps and weights over and over again.

Remember, the entire point of the GAS is to prevent our body from enduring the same damage the next time it is exposed to a certain stress. At some point, the body becomes completely adapted to a certain weight, a certain amount of reps, or a certain amount of sets. To make further progress, you'll eventually need to do more than you've done before; you'll need to progressively overload your body.



Stress—>Recovery—>Adaptation.

Photo: [Practical Programming](#) 3rd Edition, Mark Rippetoe, Aasgaard Co. 2014.

There is no way around it: *if you want to lift heavier weights and set PRs in competition, you're going to have to continually work harder in your training over time.*

## Fatigue Management

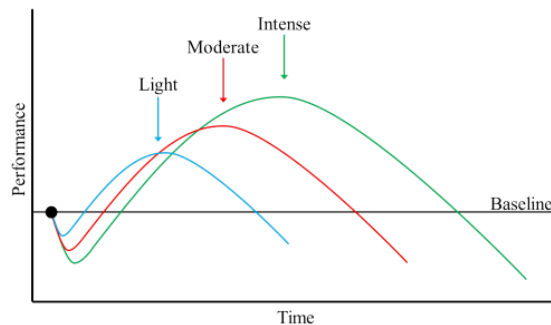
### The Use/Disuse Principle

Like anything in life, with powerlifting, if you don't use it, you lose it. This holds true for newly won strength adaptations, muscular hypertrophy, and even your ability to execute the powerlifts skillfully.

This “use and disuse” principle introduces a management problem when considered in the context of a training overload.

### The Fatigue Management Conundrum

As you will recall, training works when your lifting session represents an overload that disrupts the body’s state of homeostasis. In order to repair the damage caused by the overload, the body requires sleep, food, general resources, and, most of all, time. The larger the overload presented to the body, the more “fatigue” your body will accumulate. The more “fatigue” you accumulate, the longer it is going to take to recover.



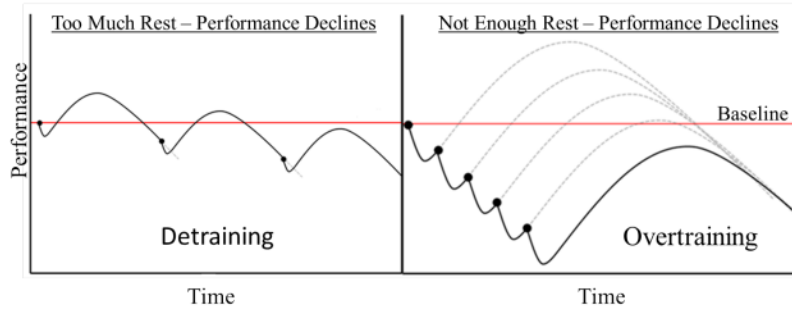
The more intense the workout, the larger the fatigue it will generate as well as the larger the result.  
photo: maxpotentialsports.com

And this is the confounding management factor. At some point, the size of the overload you’ll need to produce further adaptations is going to produce fatigue levels so high that you’ll actually begin to detrain before you’re done recovering. This necessitates that, at some point, you simply cannot perform the same workout every time. At some point, some workouts will have to be harder than others.

### It’s All About Timing

This entire process is called “fatigue management”. *Fatigue management, in a nut shell, is the process by which you time and dose your stressors (workouts) and recovery phases (rest between workouts) in order to maximize your adaptation (strength gains).* In other words, your program needs to provide enough of an overload to spur further progress, but you must also manage the fatigue these overloads create in such a manner that you neither wait so long between sessions that you start going backwards (“detraining”) nor do you perform sessions so frequently that you simply do not give yourself time for the recovery process to reach completion (“overtraining”).

## *Improper Fatigue Management: Detraining and Overtraining*



Fatigue management is a game of timing.  
photo: maxpotentialsports.com

I assure you this topic will be addressed more thoroughly in further chapters.

## Individual Differences

### Everyone Responds Slightly Differently

One of the most thoroughly neglected principles of [powerlifting programs](#), and often the one that separates “better” programs from “best” programs, is that of the law of individual differences. And what exactly is the law of individual differences? Well, *the law of individual differences very simply states that everyone responds slightly differently to training.*

This isn't to say that bench pressing will turn one man into Arnold while it turns another into a marathon runner. The law of individual differences simply tells us that even if two individuals do the exact same program, they will not get the exact same results. The precise levels of stress caused by a workout, and the resulting adaptations, are going to vary slightly from individual to individual.



These guys train **COMPLETELY** differently. If you compared two athletes of the same sport, the differences would be much smaller, but they'd still be there. That is the law of individual differences.

You see, due to age, gender, dietary status, genetics, and a list of variables so long that it is virtually impossible to cover in its entirety, everyone has different volume needs to drive progress; everyone has different recovery ability; everyone has different biomechanics which play a role in strong lifts, weak lifts, and movement selection; *everyone is just a little bit different than everyone else*.

Most programs simply ignore this fact because dealing with it makes the program “too complicated” to effectively sell as a cookie cutter template. Frankly, I’m quite adamant that if a program is not individualized, it isn’t optimal. If you’re interested in a program that is specifically designed for you personally, [PowerliftingToWin does offer coaching](#).

## Chapter 3: Programming Variables

### Programming Variables Introduction

#### Moving Forward

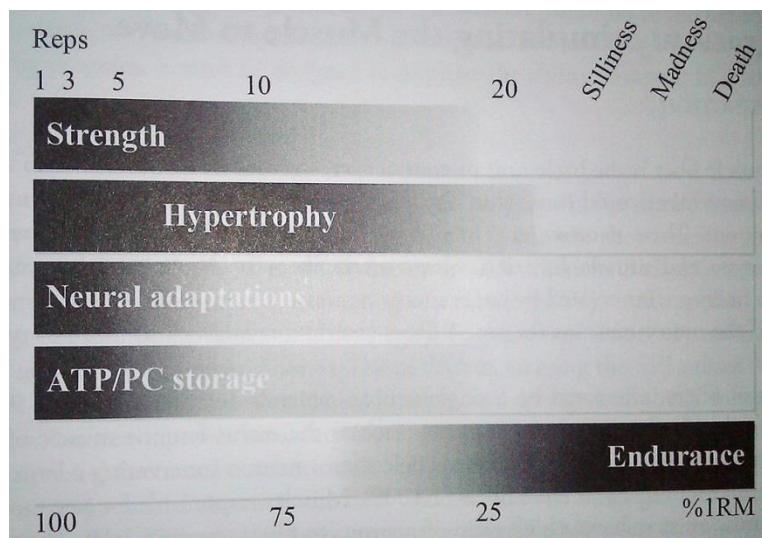
Now that we've got a solid grasp on the fundamentals of proper powerlifting programming, we're going to take a look at the programming variables that we must manipulate in order to successfully satisfy the aforementioned principles. Namely, we're going to be taking a look at intensity, volume, and frequency.

### Intensity

#### Defining Intensity

For the unfamiliar, intensity does not refer to your level of effort in the gym nor does it refer to your state of psychological arousal. *Intensity refers to the weight on the bar.* Most of the time, when intensity is being discussed, we're talking about relative intensity. In other words, if your one rep max is 100lbs, and you're about to do a set with 80lbs, the relative intensity of the set would be 80%.

*Intensity is one of the foremost considerations for any powerlifting program because intensity determines your training effect.*



This is a continuum. The further you move away from low reps, the further you get away from powerlifting specificity.  
photo: [Practical Programming](#) 3rd Edition, Mark Rippetoe, Aasgaard Co. 2014.

## Powerlifters Must Go Heavy

A large component of any one rep max is going to be neural in nature. By lifting extremely heavy weights relative to your ability, in the 90%+ range, you are going to improve overall levels of muscular recruitment as well as your general muscular coordination. In order for a powerlifting program to meet the specificity threshold, you must spend time at, and above, 90% during the appropriate times in your training cycle.

## Powerlifting and Hypertrophy

Of course, Powerlifters also have a significant need for hypertrophy. Think of a car. You can only go so far through improving the efficiency of your motor. If you want your car to go faster, at some point, you're going to need to build a bigger motor.

However, keep specificity in mind. For powerlifters, what type of additional muscle mass do you think will be of more benefit: quadriceps muscle built doing sets of twenty on the leg extension machine or quadriceps muscle built doing hard sets of ~80-85% on the squat? The answer should be obvious.

Powerlifters have no real need to spend any significant time below 75% and, realistically, the vast majority of their training on the competition lifts should be well above 80%. Once you start getting below these intensity ranges, the limiting factor on most sets starts to come down to metabolic fatigue factors such as ATP depletion, lactic acid tolerance, and other endurance components that aren't necessarily relevant to increasing powerlifting performance.

## Intensity Determines Training Effect

If you want that training effect to be specific to powerlifting, make no mistake about it, you're going to have to lift heavy.



Mike Tuchscherer pulling HEAVY at IPF World's (750lbs+/320kg+).  
photo: jtsstrength.com

# Volume

## The Role of Volume

[To borrow from Mike Tuchscherer](#), if intensity determines the training effect then *volume determines the magnitude of the training effect*.

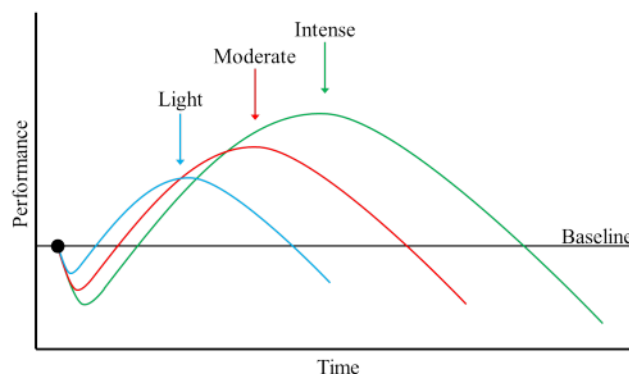
Consider a sun tan. If you spend one minute in the sun, that isn't going to produce a very appreciable level of adaptation – if it does anything at all. However, if you spend two hours in the sun that is likely going to result in you receiving a nice sun burn (“overtraining”). More importantly, there are a wide range of values in the middle. If you spend 15 minutes tanning, you'll get one level of tan, but it likely won't be as much of a tan as you'd get from 30 minutes of tanning so long as you don't get burned. Again, the sun is the intensity that determines the training effect (you get a tan), but the amount of exposure time, the volume, determines the magnitude of the training effect (how tan you become).

## Defining Volume

In terms of training, there are a number of different ways to define volume. You can talk about the total amount of reps in a workout, the total amount of sets, or, more commonly, you can discuss what is known as overall “tonnage”. Tonnage is calculated simply by multiplying the total reps by the total sets, by the amount of weight you used. For example, let's say you performed 5 sets of 5 reps with 400lbs on the squat:  $5 * 5 * 400 = 10,000\text{lbs}$ . In this case, your total tonnage was 10,000lbs.

## Volume Determines the Magnitude of the Training Effect

In oversimplified terms, your tonnage is a proxy for the magnitude of the training effect you will receive. That is, the larger your tonnage, the larger the training effect. Does that mean you should do absolutely as much volume as you can? No, it doesn't.



Again, the more volume you do, the larger the training effect.  
photo: maxpotentialsports.com

# Frequency

## Defining Frequency

To understand why, we first need to have a cursory discussion about frequency. Total frequency is generally defined by how many times you work out per week. If you squat three times per week, your frequency would be three and if you bench four times per week, your frequency would be four.

## Optimizing Frequency

When talking about Fatigue Management, we established that frequency is a game of timing. If we train too frequently, before adequate recovery has taken place, we'll begin to overtrain. Likewise, if you train too infrequently, detraining is the result. We want to hit our body with the next dose of stress at exactly the time that it is peaking from the last dose. If we can do that, we've optimized our frequency.

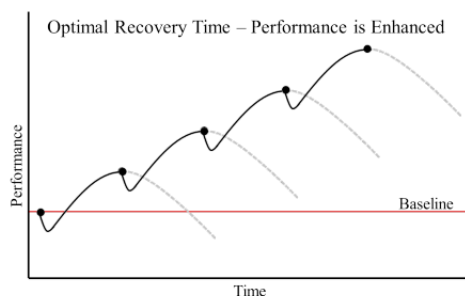


Photo: [maxpotentialsports.com](http://maxpotentialsports.com)

There is a direct relationship between volume and frequency. The more volume that you perform in a single session, the longer your recovery period from that session is going to be. To answer our original question above, the reason you do not want to do the absolute maximum amount of volume you can tolerate is because you'll pay on the back end with a longer recovery time.

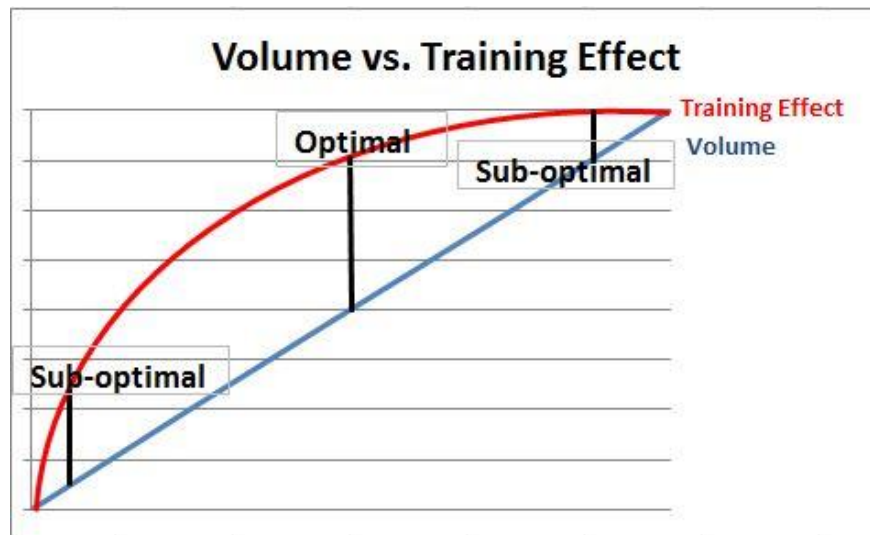
In that sense, optimal frequency is completely dependent on your volume. You have two basic considerations: timing and practicality. In terms of timing, we've already established that we need to be cognizant of the recovery curve to properly time when we're performing our next workout. However, the other consideration is that of reality. If your training sessions are starting to run 3-4 hours long because of the volume you need to perform to constitute an overload, it is time to consider upping the frequency so that you can accumulate that volume over two sessions instead.

## Optimizing Volume

### The Dose-Response Relationship

Now, I can already hear you saying: “Okay, well that’s all well and good, but if optimal frequency follows volume, how does one determine optimal volume”? That is a fantastic question and it is exceedingly difficult to answer. We’ll do our best.

In clinical settings, with all drugs, there exists something called an “optimal dose-response” relationship. Unfortunately, with training, there isn’t a linear relationship between the volume you perform and the training effect you receive. You will experience increasing returns given an increasing dose up until a certain point at which those returns will start to diminish in relation to the dose and the potential side effects.



The optimal dose of volume maximizes the training effect you get per unit of volume performed.

### Volume vs. Training Effect Example

For example, let’s say we had a crystal ball that could tell us exactly how much weight we’d add to our one rep max given a certain amount of volume. We’ll consider three scenarios:

| Total Weekly Fatigue       |                 |
|----------------------------|-----------------|
| Volume                     | Projected Gains |
| 405 for two sets of five   | 2lbs on 1RM     |
| 405 for four sets of five  | 5lbs on 1RM     |
| 405 for eight sets of five | 7lbs on 1RM     |

In a perfect world, the second scenario would result in twice the gains of the first and the third would result in twice the gains of the second. However, in reality, what tends to happen is that the very small dose might produce a 2lbs gain on your one rep max; the medium dose might produce a 5lbs gain on your one rep max; and the large dose might produce 7lbs on your one rep max.

As you can see, “optimal” volume, in this case, is four sets of five because we’re getting the greatest return for our investment. We get five pounds of gain for only doing four sets whereas the other two scenarios net us only one pound per set performed.

### The High Volume Trap

I am certain there are those of you out there saying, “Uh, who cares? Just give me the bigger gains”! However, this is a short sighted approach. Why?

Well, first of all, there are limitations to all of our time and resources. Remember, in order to drive progress, you must present your body with an overload. Guess what you have to do if your body adapts to ten sets of five? Even more volume! By jumping immediately into a high volume routine, you set yourself up for constantly needing higher and higher volumes.

Unless you’re a professional athlete, you’re going to quickly run out of time and willingness to push it further. Consider that top Sheiko athletes, such as Andre Belyaev, eventually work up to training 8-12 times per week due to their high volume approach. Are you willing to do the same?



Andre Belyaev is the All-Time World Record holder with an 890lbs deadlift at 198lbs BW.

Second, everyone has an upper limit to the total amount of volume they can recover from. While it is true that volume tolerance and recovery do improve over your training career, there is still only so much you can do in the end. By falling into what I call the “high volume trap”, you will reach this point much sooner than your peers.

In the meantime, you’ll surpass them, but, in the long run, you will have short-circuited your gains. Years down the road, when your peers eventually work up to the same volume levels as you, for each adaptive cycle, they will have received more return on their training volume investment. And because there is an upper limit to volume, by the time they’re at your volume levels, their total returns will be much higher. You will lose in the long run.

## **Moving Forward**

Now that we have a broad perspective of what optimal volume is theoretically, let's get down to the brass tacks of determining your personal, optimal volume in the real world.

## Chapter 4: Autoregulation

### Autoregulation Introduction

#### Problems with Percentage Based Programs

Traditional programming is highly flawed. The crux of the issue is that most programmers make two fatal assumptions: 1) a lifter's one rep max is fairly stable from training session to training session and 2) by knowing how much work a lifter has done, we know what effect the training session has had on them. Both assumptions are false due both to individual differences and the phenomenon of "readiness".

Autoregulation allows us to address these issues; autoregulation is the session to session adjustment of your volume and weight selection based on how you're actually performing that day.

### Readiness and Intensity

#### Defining Readiness

First, let's address readiness. If you've been lifting for more than a few months, you've undoubtedly experienced what we've all come to know as "good days" and "bad days". For whatever inexplicable reason, you are sometimes capable of lifting much heavier weights than you otherwise normally can. On other days, the exact opposite is true and you cannot match even your average performances. *Your ability to perform on any given day is called your level of "readiness".*

Now we don't always know the reason for these fluctuations. They could be completely random, they may be due to outside life stress such as a break-up, moving, getting in a fight, or even something more trivial, but what truly matters is that "life happens".

#### 85% Isn't Always 85%

When "life happens", a program that calls for a fixed percentage, of some theoretical one rep max that you did that one time in the past, might have you working much lighter or heavier than intended. For example, if a program calls for "85%", that typically results in about five reps. On good days, however, 85% might lead you to get 7-8 reps. On bad days, 85% might lead you to get only 2-3 reps. 85% isn't always 85%. It depends on your readiness which constantly fluctuates. With fixed programming prescriptions we can't be sure that we are actually doing 85% for that particular day's level of readiness.

## Volume and Fatigue

### Volume Does NOT Equal Training Effect

Perhaps the biggest miscue of [traditional programming](#) is the assumption that if you can prescribe the volume, you can prescribe the training effect. This couldn't be less true and it is due both to readiness and individual differences.

### Individual Differences, Volume, and Training Effect

In terms of individual differences, this problem becomes rather obvious. Say we have two trainees: a 55 year old master's lifter on a calorically restricted diet and an 18 year old novice lifter currently gaining 1-2lbs a week. Their age, nutrition, and training advancement are completely different. Are we really going to be so foolish to assume that a "5x5" workout is going to have the same effect on these two lifters? For the older lifter, a true, difficult 5x5 may cripple them for an entire week. For our growing novice, this might be just enough volume to push him forwards for his next workout two days later.

### Fatigue vs. Volume

We have to differentiate between fatigue and volume. They're highly correlated, but they're not synonymous. The higher the level of volume tolerance an individual possesses, the less fatigue a given amount of volume is going to cause. Because "fatigue" is the far better proxy for the size of the dose of stress we've given the body, we're more interested in how much fatigue a workout has caused rather than how much volume it contains. We need to *begin to think of volume as the tool that we use to create fatigue rather than thinking of it as what literally drives progress.*

### Optimal Volume is Day to Day

Readiness is also largely important when it comes to fatigue considerations. That is, even for the exact same individual, different levels of volume will cause different levels of fatigue on certain days.

Let's say that, hypothetically, you only got two hours of sleep last night, you had to fight traffic for two hours on the way home from work, and, when you finally get home, you find that your dog got sick and threw up all over the living room. Do you think that you're going to be able to handle the same amount of volume as usual? Even if you can, do you think it will cause the same amount of fatigue? No, of course it won't. Stress is cumulative.

### Identify the Problem, Then Fix It

Because of these problems, preplanned, prewritten programs based on percentages are highly flawed. What we truly need is a way to regulate our weights and volume on any given training session to ensure they both address individual differences and match a particular individual's level of readiness that day. Let's take a look at how we can do that.

## RPE: Rate of Perceived Exertion

### Introducing RPE

While RPE was first mentioned in a lifting context in [Supertraining](#), it was really [Mike Tuchscherer's Reactive Training Systems](#) that first popularized the concept amongst powerlifters. RPE stands for rate of perceived exertion. RPE is a subjective indicator that gives us a way to communicate the difficulty of a set.

### Reactive Training Systems RPE Chart:



Photo: [www.reactivetrainingsystems.com](http://www.reactivetrainingsystems.com)

### Autoregulating Intensity with RPE

What is the significance of RPE you ask? RPE allows us to ensure that we are working in the proper intensity zone during any given workout. Rather than prescribe someone a fixed percentage, that may or may not correlate to their readiness that day, we can prescribe reps and RPE.

Just for example, we know that a five rep max is about 85%. Instead of telling the lifter to do 85% of their theoretical one rep max, we just tell them to “work up” to x5@10. Depending on their readiness that day, the weight is going to be different. This is autoregulation; your weight selection is determined by how you’re doing on THAT particular day. Instead of you fitting to the program, the program fits to you.

### The RPE Chart

We can use the following chart to get an idea of what any particular rep/RPE combo will give us in terms of intensity:

|     | 1    | 2   | 3   | 4   | 5   | 6   | 7   | 8   | 9   | 10  |
|-----|------|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|
| 10  | 100% | 96% | 92% | 89% | 86% | 84% | 81% | 79% | 76% | 74% |
| 9.5 | 98%  | 94% | 91% | 88% | 85% | 82% | 80% | 77% | 75% | 72% |
| 9   | 96%  | 92% | 89% | 86% | 84% | 81% | 79% | 76% | 74% | 71% |
| 8.5 | 94%  | 91% | 88% | 85% | 82% | 80% | 77% | 75% | 72% | 69% |
| 8   | 92%  | 89% | 86% | 84% | 81% | 79% | 76% | 74% | 71% | 68% |
| 7.5 | 91%  | 88% | 85% | 82% | 80% | 77% | 75% | 72% | 69% | 67% |
| 7   | 89%  | 86% | 84% | 81% | 79% | 76% | 74% | 71% | 68% | 65% |
| 6.5 | 88%  | 85% | 82% | 80% | 77% | 75% | 72% | 69% | 67% | 64% |

### No More Percentages

With a firm grasp of RPE, you can see that we no longer need fixed percentage prescriptions anyways. With RPE, we can always work in the exact intensity range that we were intending. Instead of our weights being based on some theoretical max that might have happened three or four months ago, our weight selection is completely autoregulated by our performance during each workout. On good days, you’ll take advantage and smash PRs. On bad days, you’ll also take advantage by avoiding going too heavy, missing lifts, and just digging yourself into a recovery deficit.

## Fatigue Matters

### Autoregulating Volume

As you’ll recall, the second issue with [traditional percentage based programming](#) was that of fixed volume prescriptions. *We don’t necessarily care about how much total volume our trainees are doing. We care what effect that volume is having.* In other words, we need a way to measure fatigue versus simply measuring volume.

### Fatigue Percents

Using RPEs, we can now do that through a concept called “fatigue percents”. For example, let’s say our workout prescription calls for x5@9 (five reps with one rep left in the tank). Instead of telling a lifter to do five sets at x5@8-9 or something like that, we can prescribe them “5% fatigue instead”.

### Fatigue Percent Example

Here is how it works:

1) The lifter works up to their initial top set. Let’s say 500x5@9

- 2) The lifter then subtracts 5% from this number to get 475.
- 3) The lifter will repeat sets at 475 until he hits an RPE 9. This may take one set or it may take ten sets.
- 4) Once an RPE 9 is reached at 475, we know that “5% fatigue” has occurred because he is now doing 5% less weight with the exact same difficulty as he did 500. In simple terms, his lifting ability has dropped 5%. Boom! We now have a way to measure fatigue instead of volume.

### *Just The Numbers*

455x5@7

480x5@8

500x5@9, this is the “initial”

475x5@8

475x5@8.5

475x5@9, 5% fatigue reached – workout over

### **Why Autoregulate Volume?**

This autoregulation of volume is critical for so many reasons. As we’ve already mentioned, it doesn’t necessarily matter how much volume you do, it matters what effect the volume is having. By managing fatigue, instead of volume, the volume is autoregulated until it has the precise effect we want it to have. For older lifters, it will take less volume to reach the same amount of fatigue. For lifters having a great day, it will take more volume than usual. Regardless, the volume for that session is completely optimized to the lifter.

## **Using Fatigue Percentages**

### **Practical Application**

There are a few important guidelines in terms of using fatigue percents in the real world: 1) understanding the effect of different percentage ranges and 2) time limits.

Understand that the following represents guidelines. I have pulled this information directly from [the RTS Manual](#), formatted the tables, and added my own notations for further clarity and understanding.

The following % ranges are determined entirely from Mike Tuchscherer’s practical experience coaching hundreds of athletes. Nonetheless, practical experience is always subject to error. Keep that in mind. These percentages may not work out exactly for you. Take notes, pay attention, and adjust over time.

## Weekly Fatigue and Stress

| Total Weekly Fatigue |              |                                                                                 |
|----------------------|--------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Fatigue Percent      | Stress Level | My Notes                                                                        |
| 54-72%               | Very High    | Extremely high volume. This is similar to the Smolov Base Mesocycle.            |
| 36-54%               | High         | Designed to cause overreaching. You won't fully recover at the end of the week. |
| 24-36%               | Medium       | This is about the most you can do and still recover at the end of the week.     |
| 12-18%               | Low          | This is perfect for a recovery week without a full deload.                      |
| 0%                   | Deload       | This is a straight up deload week.                                              |

### Exercise Fatigue and Stress:

The following assumes three exercises per workout. We're talking specifically about individual exercise fatigue here.

| Individual Exercise Fatigue |             |
|-----------------------------|-------------|
| Fatigue Percent             | Time Limit  |
| 9-12%                       | 96 Hours+   |
| 6-9%                        | 72-96 Hours |
| 4-6%                        | 48-72 Hours |
| 2-3%                        | 24-48 Hours |
| 0%                          | 24 Hours    |

### Why We Need Time Limits

As far as time limits go, obviously, you're going to be able to do more back-off sets if you rest fifteen minutes between sets. That isn't the point here.

We need to keep the workouts to a reasonable length because: a) we're not professional athletes, b) this allows us to add more volume over time without running into scheduling issues, and c) most importantly, a time limit gives us a way to standardize each session; when conditions are vastly different in terms of time limits, fatigue %s lose some of their value because you can't compare 5% fatigue accumulated on 3-5 minute rests to fatigue accumulated on 15-20 minute rests. You need to compare apples to apples.

### Time Limits for Fatigue Percent Ranges

The time limit begins as soon as you start your first warm-up with weights on the bar.

| Time Limit Guidelines |               |
|-----------------------|---------------|
| Fatigue Percent       | Time Limit    |
| 9-12%                 | 30-35 minutes |
| 6-9%                  | 25-28 minutes |
| 4-6%                  | 20-22 minutes |
| 2-3%                  | 18-20 minutes |
| 0%                    | 15-18 minutes |

## Fatigue Percent Methods

### Different Ways to use Fatigue Percent

While Tuchscherer discusses many different means and methods of using fatigue percents in [the RTS Manual](#), I'm going to familiarize you with only two of them because those are one the ones we'll be using in our programming here.

### Load Drops

The first method is called the "load drop". We've already discussed this method without naming it. With the load drop method, you simply work up to an initial set, take off the prescribed % (drop the load), and then perform back-off sets with the lowered weight until you hit the same RPE as the initial set.

#### *Load Drop Example*

90x3@7  
95x3@8  
100x3@9, 10% load drop  
90x3@7  
90x3@7.5  
90x3@8  
90x3@8.5  
90x3@9, 10% fatigue reached

### Repeats

Repeats are somewhat similar to load drops excepting that we don't work up to our highest RPE initially. Instead, we find a lower initial weight and repeat that weight until it becomes a higher RPE. This generally results in more overall volume being done at a lower average intensity. This makes it great for when you're specifically shooting for a high volume workout and/or when you want to avoid higher intensity ranges

#### *Repeats Example*

90x3@7  
95x3@8  
95x3@8  
95x3@8.5  
95x3@8.5  
95x3@9, 3% fatigue reached

### Calculating Fatigue When Using Repeats

To calculate how much fatigue you're accumulating from repeat sets, using the following chart:

| Fatigue and Repeats |            |         |
|---------------------|------------|---------|
| RPE Increase        | Example    | Fatigue |
| 0.5                 | 8.0-->8.5  | 2-3%    |
| 1                   | 8.0-->9.0  | 4-6%    |
| 1.5                 | 8.0-->9.5  | 6-9%    |
| 2                   | 8.0-->10.0 | 9-12%   |

## Chapter 5: Training Organization

### Training Organization Fundamentals

#### The Three Levels of Zoom

Our discussion thus far has brought us to the point where we have discussed both the scientific underpinnings of proper powerlifting programming as well as the variables that must be manipulated in order to satisfy the requirements of those principles. The next logical step to take is to begin to organize this information into actual [powerlifting programs](#). Before we can do that, a discussion of the organization of powerlifting training as a whole is necessary.

Borrowing from [Mladen Jovanović's](#) concept of the “Three Levels of Zoom”, training organization can be broken down into three component parts: planning, periodization, and programming.

|              | Description                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| First Level  | Periodizing annual training plan based on context, competition schedule and laws of sport form development                                                                                            |
|              | Defining/listing training goals based on the sport analysis and athletes evaluation and thus creating a strengths~weaknesses analysis                                                                 |
| Second Level | Organization of development/reaching of the defined goals                                                                                                                                             |
| Third Level  | Development of sub-goals<br><b>Specificity of exercises/methods used</b><br>Load progressions and planning (concentrated~distributed)<br>Microcycle planning (fatigue management)<br>Auto-regulations |

This is Jovanović's original table. I have made modifications to his definitions as you will see.  
Photo: [complementarytraining.blogspot.com](http://complementarytraining.blogspot.com)

### Planning

The first and foremost consideration of training organization is the reality of the competitive calendar. That is, you need to know the date of every important meet that you intend to compete in throughout the year. The contest dates dictate how many weeks of training you will have between competitions. This information is necessary to design training cycles that produce peak performance at the right times throughout the year.

*An Example of an Annual Sporting Plan:*

**Conceptual Periodized Training Diagram**

| Trans. Phase |       |       | Preparatory Phase |           |       |       |       |           |       |       |       | Competitive Phase |       |
|--------------|-------|-------|-------------------|-----------|-------|-------|-------|-----------|-------|-------|-------|-------------------|-------|
| Macrocycle   |       |       |                   |           |       |       |       |           |       |       |       |                   |       |
| Mesocycle    |       |       |                   | Mesocycle |       |       |       | Mesocycle |       |       |       |                   |       |
| Micro        | Micro | Micro | Micro             | Micro     | Micro | Micro | Micro | Micro     | Micro | Micro | Micro | Micro             | Micro |
| Training     |       |       |                   |           |       |       |       |           |       |       |       | Contest           |       |
| Jan          | Feb   | Mar   | Apr               | May       | Jun   | Jul   | Aug   | Sep       | Oct   | Nov   | Dec   | Jan               |       |

An example of an annual plan for an athlete doing only meet per year.  
photo: elitefts.com

### Athlete Resources

An additional practical consideration to make here is that of the athlete's resources. How many days a week can they train? How much time in the day does the athlete have available to dedicate to training? Does the athlete have any vacations or important life events on the horizon? Questions of this nature must be addressed before you can get into the actual details of program design. The perfect theoretical program often starts to break down in the face of life's realities.

### Athlete Ability and Advancement

Finally, we must consider what the level of training advancement of the athlete we are dealing with is. The overall plan for an internationally competitive lifter is markedly different than that of the novice. The variables to focus upon and consider for each population are on the opposite ends of the spectrum.

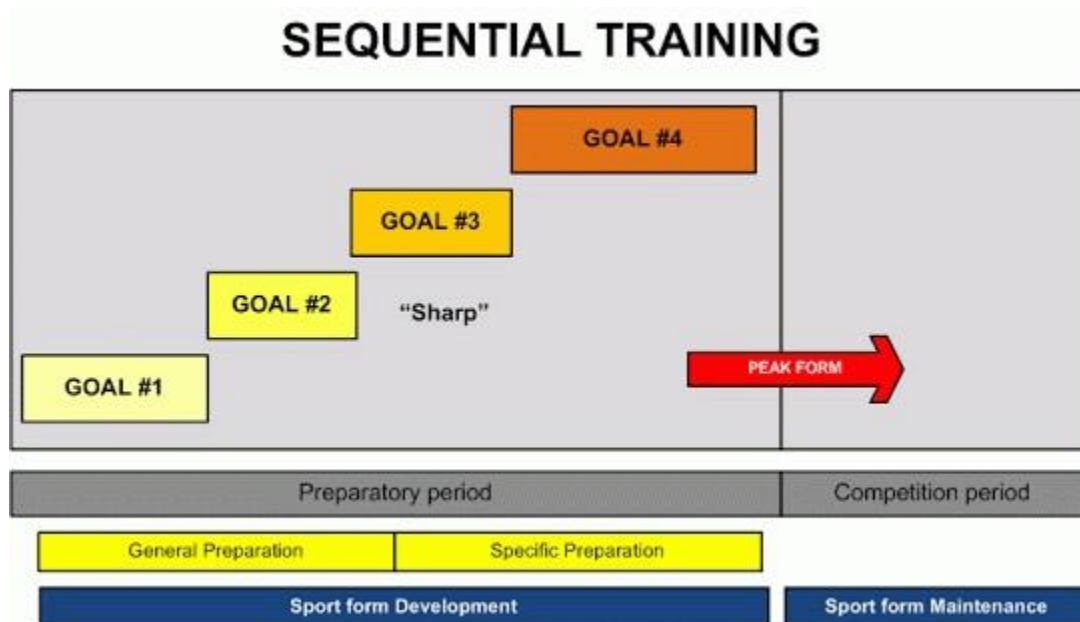
## Periodization

### Defining Periodization

Periodization is an incredibly tricky concept to discuss because there is no accepted definition. Some refer to periodization as merely any type of programmatic planning whatsoever. Depending on who you are listening to, periodization can refer to anything from linear progression to that of an Olympic quadrennial training cycle. Such a broad definition has no utility for our purposes and, thus, admittedly, we're going to do a bit of redefining here.

For our purposes, and for what I'd suggest as a more practical use in general, *we will define periodization as the organization of training objectives over a training cycle*. For example, an athlete

might spend the first third of his training cycle on hypertrophy, the second third on speed, and the final third on strength. Without discussing any of the programmatic details such as volume, intensity, exercise selection, frequency, or others, this is what we're referring to when discussing periodization; we're discussing the manner in which the training cycle is organized to focus on specific objectives at specific times.



An example of sequential block periodization.  
photo: [complementarytraining.blogspot.com](http://complementarytraining.blogspot.com)

## Programming

### Defining Programming

Finally, after having established our competitive timeline, and having organized the objectives of our training cycle into a logical sequence, we can discuss actual programming. For our purposes, *programming specifically refers to the manipulation of intensity, volume, frequency, rest periods, exercise selection, and any other details that make up the stuff and substance of an individual training session.*

## Chapter 6: Training Advancement – Novice, Intermediate, or Advanced?

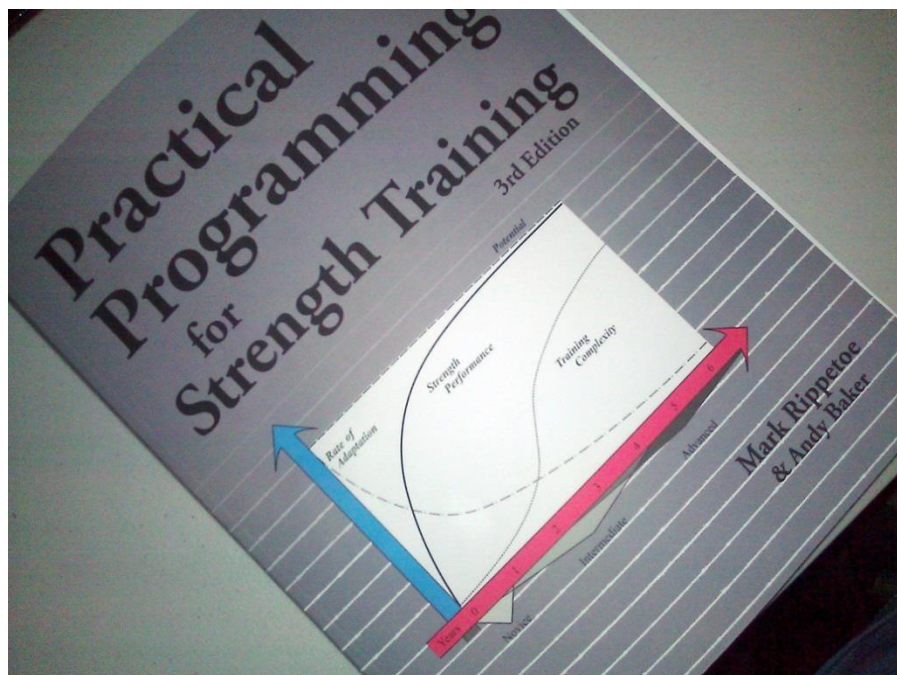
### The Novice and the Advanced Athlete Should Train Differently

When it comes to the organization and development of powerlifting training, programming receives the lion's share of the attention. However, without context, this can often lead to poor results. I can develop the best program in the entire world, but if that program was developed for the advanced athlete, and I give the program to a novice lifter, we have a mismatch of substantial proportions. The program will be needlessly complex, and, in actuality, result in less progress than a simpler prescription. This is why we must start at the first level of zoom: planning.

### Practical Classification of Athletes

However, this raises the question of classification. What exactly is a novice? How can we accurately differentiate between trainees in a manner that allows us to make practical decisions regarding periodization and programming? Should we classify athletes based on strength level? What about training age?

In [Practical Programming](#), Mark Rippetoe pioneered the idea that athlete classification should be based on the type of programming that is effective for any given athlete. The argument is compelling for several reasons.



[Practical Programming](#) is the best introductory text ever written on proper programming for lifting.

### Strength Levels Do NOT Determine Classification

Due to differences in genetics, recovery habits, lifestyle, and a myriad of other factors, *it is impossible to determine whether or not someone is a “novice” based on their strength levels*. It isn't entirely unheard of for some people to use basic linear progression programs, where you simply add 5lbs per workout, every workout, all the way up into the 400s and 500s on their squat. Most people might assume that if you are squatting 405lbs/185kg for multiple sets of five reps, you are surely not a novice. This simply isn't always the case.

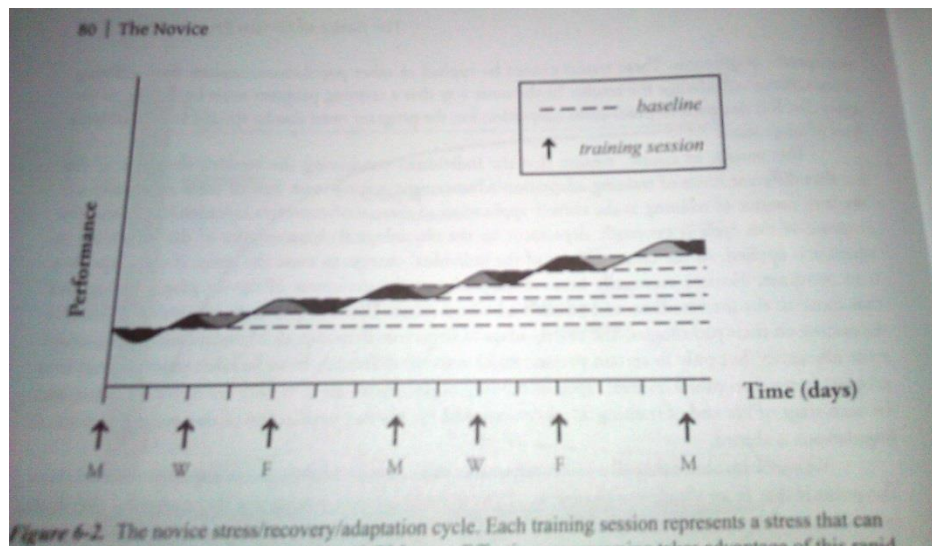
Personally, my linear progression on squats ended at 445lbs/202kg for five reps. Many coaches might have moved me to more complex intermediate programs with slower progression schemes before I had fully exhausted my novice gains if they tried to base whether I was a novice or an intermediate off of my strength levels. Realistically, strength levels simply aren't enough to determine classification.

### How Long You've Been Training Does NOT Determine Classification

Training age is similarly limited. There are innumerable cases of trainees who, despite having been in the weight room for years, have made little progress due to poor programming. Many trainees spend years doing bodybuilding routines from the popular magazines that just don't seem to work effectively. These types of trainees are best suited for novice-style programs. Having never engaged in a proper strength program before, they're still capable of some “beginner” gains.

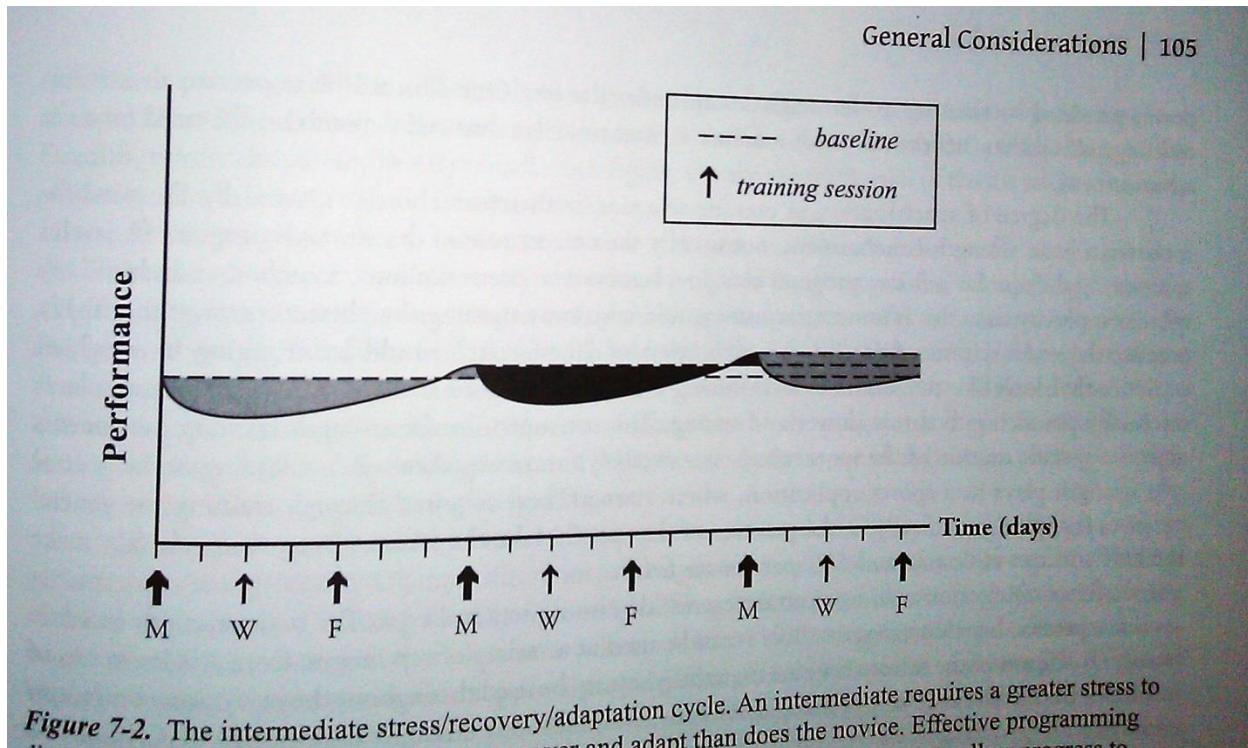
## Rippetoe's Classification System

With this in mind, Rippetoe suggested that a novice lifter be defined as any lifter that is capable of making progress from workout to workout.



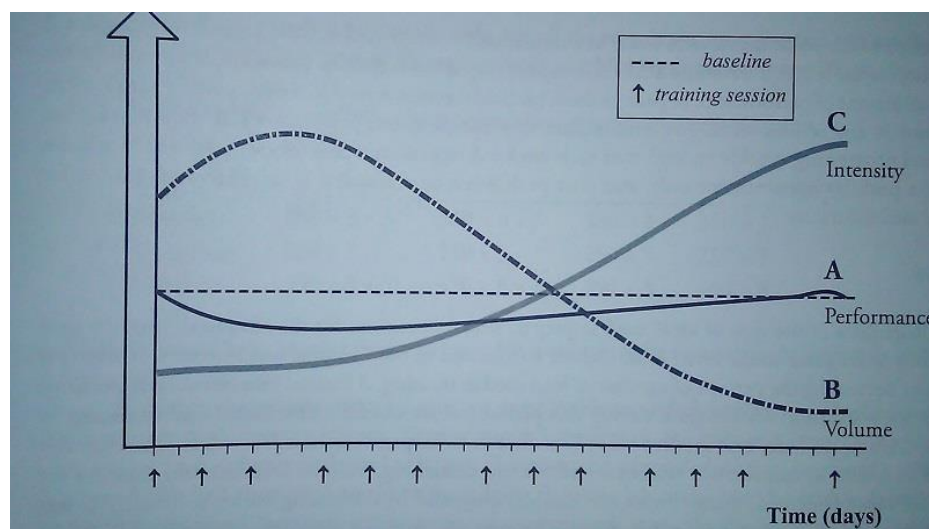
The Novice adapts within 48-72 hours.  
photo: [Practical Programming](#) 3rd Ed, Mark Rippetoe, 2014.

He defines an intermediate trainee as anyone who can make progress on a weekly basis.



Rippetoe's Intermediate lifter requires a full week to complete an adaptive cycle.  
photo: [Practical Programming](#) 3rd Ed, Mark Rippetoe, 2014.

For Rip, advanced trainees are those who require more than a week of training to make progress – typically, a month or longer would be required for these folks.

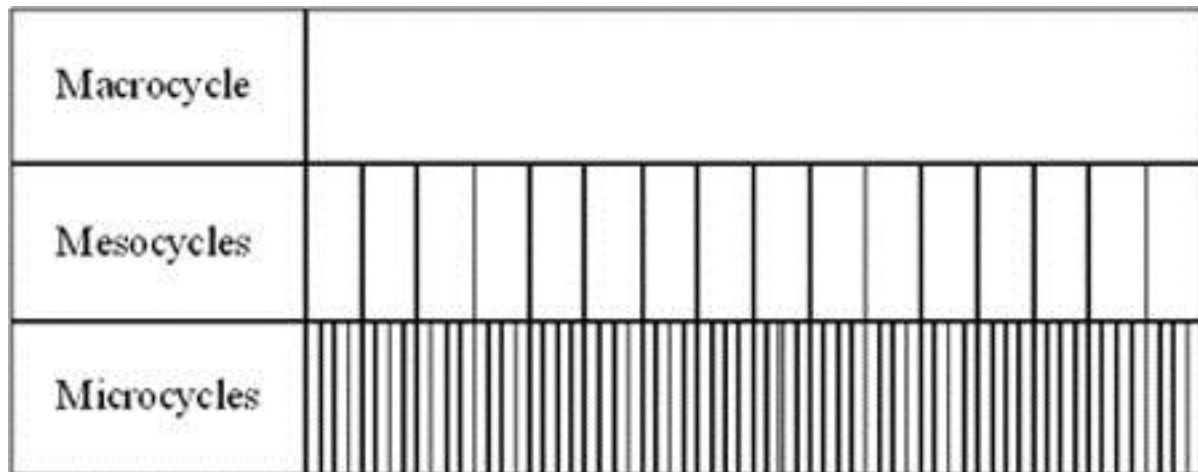


Rippetoe's Advanced Lifter requires a full month to complete an adaptive cycle.  
photo: [Practical Programming](#) 3rd Ed, Mark Rippetoe, 2014.

## Microcycles and Mesocycles

Rippetoe's trainee classifications are predicated on the length of an individual's training cycle. Most academic sources are going to refer to training cycles with the following terms: microcycles and mesocycles.

A mesocycle is a complete "period" of training. For example, if we dedicated four weeks to focusing on hypertrophy, those four weeks would constitute the mesocycle. Typically, a microcycle is going to be a training period within the mesocycle. For example, in our four week hypertrophy example, the microcycles would probably consist of each individual week within that month long mesocycle.



Mesocycles are specific blocks within the season and microcycles make up mesocycle (usually training weeks).  
Photo: [runwashington.com](http://runwashington.com)

## Novices, Mesocycles, and Microcycles

For Rippetoe, a novice is someone for whom the length of an entire mesocycle is one workout. The novice is expected to go through an entire stress-recovery-adaptation cycle inside of 48-72 hours. For the true novice, their mesocycles and microcycles are the exact same length. In other words, each workout is both a full mesocycle and a full microcycle.

## Intermediates, Mesocycles, and Microcycles

For Rippetoe, the intermediate trainee is someone for whom the length of an entire mesocycle is one week. During that week, each workout would consist of a microcycle. Let's consider Rippetoe's go-to intermediate program: [The Texas Method](#).

### *Sample Texas Method Program*

| The Texas Method |                                                                          |                                                                                          |                                                    |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
|                  | Mon                                                                      | Wed                                                                                      | Fri                                                |
| Week One         | Squat: 5x5@80-90% of Fri<br>Bench: 5x5@80-90% of Fri<br>Power Clean: 5x3 | Squat: 2x5@80-90% of Mon<br>Press: 3x5@80-90% of Last Mon<br>GHR/Back Extension: 3x10-15 | Squat: 1x5@PR<br>Bench: 1x5@PR<br>Deadlift: 1x5@PR |
| Week Two         | Squat: 5x5@80-90% of Fri<br>Press: 5x5@80-90% of Fri<br>Power Clean: 5x3 | Squat: 2x5@80-90% of Mon<br>Bench: 3x5@80-90% of Last Mon<br>GHR/Back Extension: 3x10-15 | Squat: 1x5@PR<br>Press: 1x5@PR<br>Deadlift: 1x5@PR |

*Adapted from the Starting Strength Seminar for Starting Strength Coaches.*

### **Texas Method Explanation**

With this particular set-up, the entire week mimics the stress-recovery-adaptation cycle. Monday is known as “Volume Day” on the Texas Method. This workout constitutes the major stressor of the week and is what drives progress on the program. The Wednesday workout is a “Recovery Day”. On Recovery Day, the volume and intensity are greatly reduced to promote recovery. The purpose of this training session is to prevent detraining while the lifter recovers. Friday is known as “Intensity Day”. On Intensity Day, you demonstrate the new adaptation caused by Monday’s workout by going for a PR. As you can see, the weekly Texas Method mesocycle represents a full cycle of the General Adaptation Syndrome.

## **The Problem with Classification Based on Training Cycle Length**

### **The Training Advancement Continuum**

While Rippetoe’s ideas on athlete classification are quite novel and useful at the earliest stages of training, they quickly lose utility for anyone who has been training for a few years. As Rippetoe would fully admit, training advancement is not a black and white concept. Training advancement is a continuum.

### **The Training Advancement Continuum and Novices**

For example, when you initially start training as a novice, you might only need 24 hours between workouts to fully recover. However, by the time you’ve been training for 3-6 months, you might need up to 72 hours before you’re ready for your next workout. You can easily see how treating all novices the same might lead to inappropriate programming within a training week.

### **The Training Advancement Continuum and Intermediates**

The problem becomes magnified at the intermediate level of training. The Texas Method requires weekly PRs which is an incredible rate of progress. Even at 2.5lbs of progress per training week, you’re looking at increasing a given lift over 100lbs in a year. That is not realistically sustainable for very long.

If we guess that the novice phase lasts 3-9 months, and that something like the Texas Method might be sustainable for another 6-12 months after that (not without some stalls and resets along the way, mind you) then what we're left with is the idea that anyone who has been training for two years is an advanced athlete.

The reality is that the person who just finished the Texas Method is far from an advanced athlete and can still make progress using very simple programming. They do not need to launch into complex twelve to sixteen week periodization models right off of the bat.

## The PowerliftingToWin Athlete Classification System

### Defining Novice, Intermediate, and Advanced

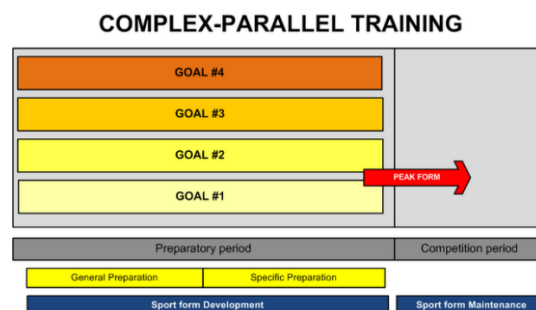
Let me propose what I believe to be a more useful way to classify novice, intermediate, and advanced athletes. While I agree with Rippetoe's ideas on the low utility of classification based on strength level and/or training age, I propose that trainee classification should be made based on what type of periodization and programming is necessary for the athlete rather than on mesocycle length.

### Definition of the Novice Trainee

*A novice lifter is any lifter that does not require periods of specific emphasis on particular performance attributes nor programmatic variety in terms of variables such as intensity and volume.*

---

In simple terms, a novice doesn't need to have periods of explicit focus on hypertrophy, strength, technique, or speed. One of the hallmarks of novice training is that the novice requires very little volume to make progress. As such, they can use what is known as "Complex-Parallel" Periodization – a form of periodization where attributes such as strength, hypertrophy, and speed are progressed simultaneously during training.



Visualizing Complex-Parallel Periodization  
photo: [complementarytraining.blogspot.com](http://complementarytraining.blogspot.com)

Likewise, a novice doesn't require variation from workout to workout. Because the novice can complete a full stress-recovery-adaptation cycle in 48-72 hours, they are best suited to performing the same exact workout every single time they enter the gym. The only difference being that they add weight to bar every single workout.

Remember, one of the primary goals of training is to help the athlete reach their objectives as expeditiously as possible. Why go for slower progression protocols when an athlete can simply set a PR every single time they go to the gym? Anything less than workout to workout PR's is unnecessarily slow for the novice.

### Definition of the Intermediate Trainee

*An intermediate trainee is any trainee who does not require periods of specific emphasis on particular performance attributes, but who DOES require programmatic variety in terms of intensity and volume.*

---

Like the novice, the intermediate trainee can still make use of Complex-Parallel periodization. They are not so advanced that the volume requirements of improving a given quality are so high that they would simply overtrain if they tried to improve them all at once; they're still more than capable of improving all the relevant qualities simultaneously.

However, an intermediate trainee is advanced enough that they require much longer than 48-72 hours for a full stress-recovery-adaptation cycle to take place. As such, intensity and volume must be manipulated.

Consider again the [Texas Method](#). An early stage intermediate trainee might use the typical Monday Volume, Wednesday Recovery, and Friday Intensity set-up. A slightly more advanced trainee might space this out to Week 1 Volume, Week 2 Recovery, and Week 3 Intensity. All qualities are still going to be attacked simultaneously, but we're now getting more and more complex with our manipulation of intensity and volume.

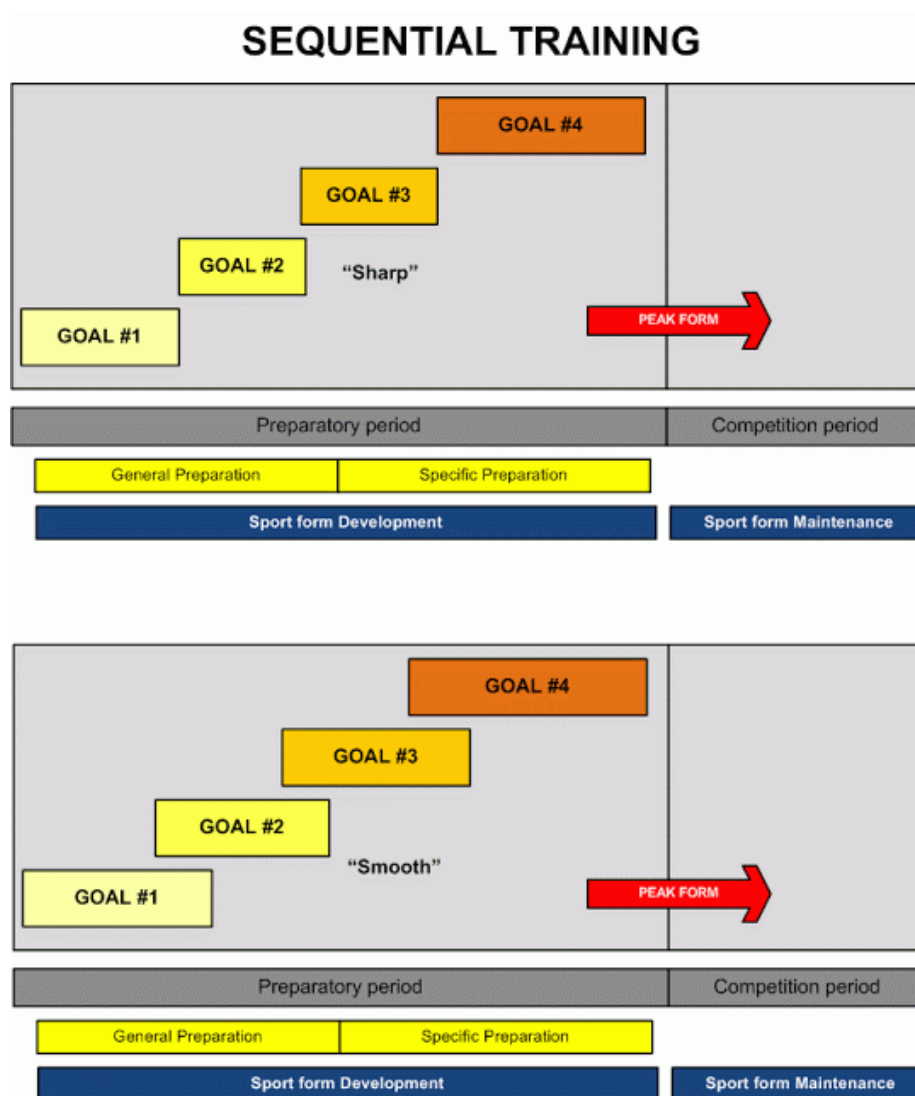
### Definition of The Advanced Trainee

*An advanced trainee is any trainee who requires both periods of specific emphasis on particular performance attributes AND programmatic variety in terms of intensity and volume.*

---

The hallmark of the advanced athlete is their volume requirements. An advanced athlete is so highly trained that in order to improve their strength or their speed, they need volumes which prohibit focusing on multiple qualities simultaneously. That is, in order to get stronger, they need so much strength training that they have to put hypertrophy style training on maintenance. Then, when they need to get bigger, they need to put strength style training on maintenance in order to fit in enough hypertrophy volume to prevent overtraining.

Keep in mind, just as with intermediates, this need does exist along a continuum. An “early” advanced athlete might use a “pendulum” approach to periodization. That is, during the off-season, they might focus 70% on hypertrophy and 30% on strength. Throughout the training cycle, the emphasis might swing towards 30% hypertrophy and 70% strength. Only the most advanced athletes are going to use periodization schemes with anything approaching 100% focus on a specific performance attribute.



“Sharp” sequential block periodization is more appropriate for the highly advanced athlete whereas the “Smooth” approach might be used for an athlete with lower overall volume requirements for improvement.

photo: [complementarytraining.blogspot.com](http://complementarytraining.blogspot.com)

## Visualizing Training Advancement

To put this all into context, and demonstrate the differences between levels of advancement, I want to provide some very general, theoretical examples of how a novice, intermediate, and advanced program might be put together.

| Theoretical Examples               |                               |                              |                               |
|------------------------------------|-------------------------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| Novice                             |                               |                              |                               |
| Periodization Focus<br>Programming | Mesocycle 1                   | Mesocycle 2                  | Mesocycle 3                   |
|                                    | All Attributes                | All Attributes               | All Attributes                |
|                                    | Static                        | Static                       | Static                        |
| Intermediate                       |                               |                              |                               |
| Periodization Focus<br>Programming | Mesocycle 1                   | Mesocycle 2                  | Mesocycle 3                   |
|                                    | All Attributes                | All Attributes               | All Attributes                |
|                                    | High Volume, Medium Intensity | Low Volume, Medium Intensity | Medium Volume, High Intensity |
| Advanced                           |                               |                              |                               |
| Periodization Focus<br>Programming | Mesocycle 1                   | Mesocycle 2                  | Mesocycle 3                   |
|                                    | Hypertrophy                   | Speed                        | Strength                      |
|                                    | High Volume, Medium Intensity | Low Volume, Medium Intensity | Medium Volume, High Intensity |

With each new stage of training advancement, complexity is layered into the overall training approach.

## Chapter 7: Programming Principles Summary

### Program Design

#### Bringing It All Together

We now possess all the tools we need to start evaluating and creating our own novice and intermediate programs. We understand the scientific underpinnings of proper programming, we know what programmatic variables we must manipulate in order to comply with those principles, and we have a broad overview of how to organize those principles into a coherent plan of action.

#### An Overview of the First Six Chapters

Before we begin with the actual programs, I'd like to briefly key-in on some critical concepts:

#### Specificity

The carryover you get from improving an exercise depends on how specific that exercise is to the competition lift. To become good at squatting, benching, and deadlifting heavy weights, most of our training must revolve around squatting, benching, and deadlifting heavy weights.

#### Overload

In order to improve, you must do more than you've done before. The body must be overloaded via more reps, more weight, more sets, less rest time, or some other variable that makes the workout harder.

#### Fatigue Management

We adapt to training via the General Adaptation Syndrome. Our body is exposed to a stress, we recover, and we adapt via supercompensation to come back bigger and stronger.

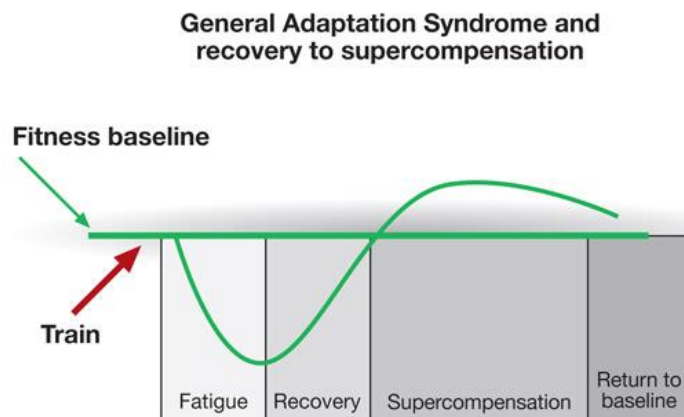
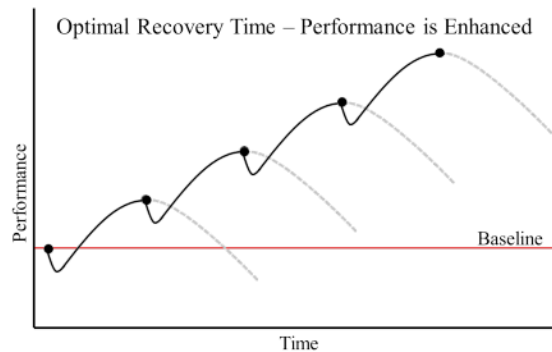


Photo: [heatrick.com](http://heatrick.com)

If we train too frequently, or with too much volume, we overwhelm this process in the short term. If we don't train frequently enough, we lose our hard won adaptations and go backwards. Proper timing of workouts and proper dosing of volume is critical to managing fatigue and making progress.



Remember, Fatigue Management is a game of timing.  
photo: maxpotentialsports.com

## Individual Differences

Without autoregulation, we can't be sure that our training is having the effect we want. 85% is not always 85%. Everyone has different volume needs. Even the same person has different volume needs on different days. Without some degree of individualization, without some degree of autoregulation, we cannot optimize intensity and volume.

## Planning

Planning takes into the larger picture. When is the next meet? Is the athlete a novice? How many days a week can they train? How is real life going to impact our competitive plan?

## Periodization

Unlike traditional usage, our definition of periodization refers to the organization of goals during a particular training period.



This is an example of sequential block periodization where one goal is focused upon per period.  
photo: complementary.blogspot.com

For example, the first four weeks of training might focus on hypertrophy while the second four weeks might focus on strength. This says nothing about intensity, volume, or other programming variables. Periodization is the organization of training goals.

### Programming

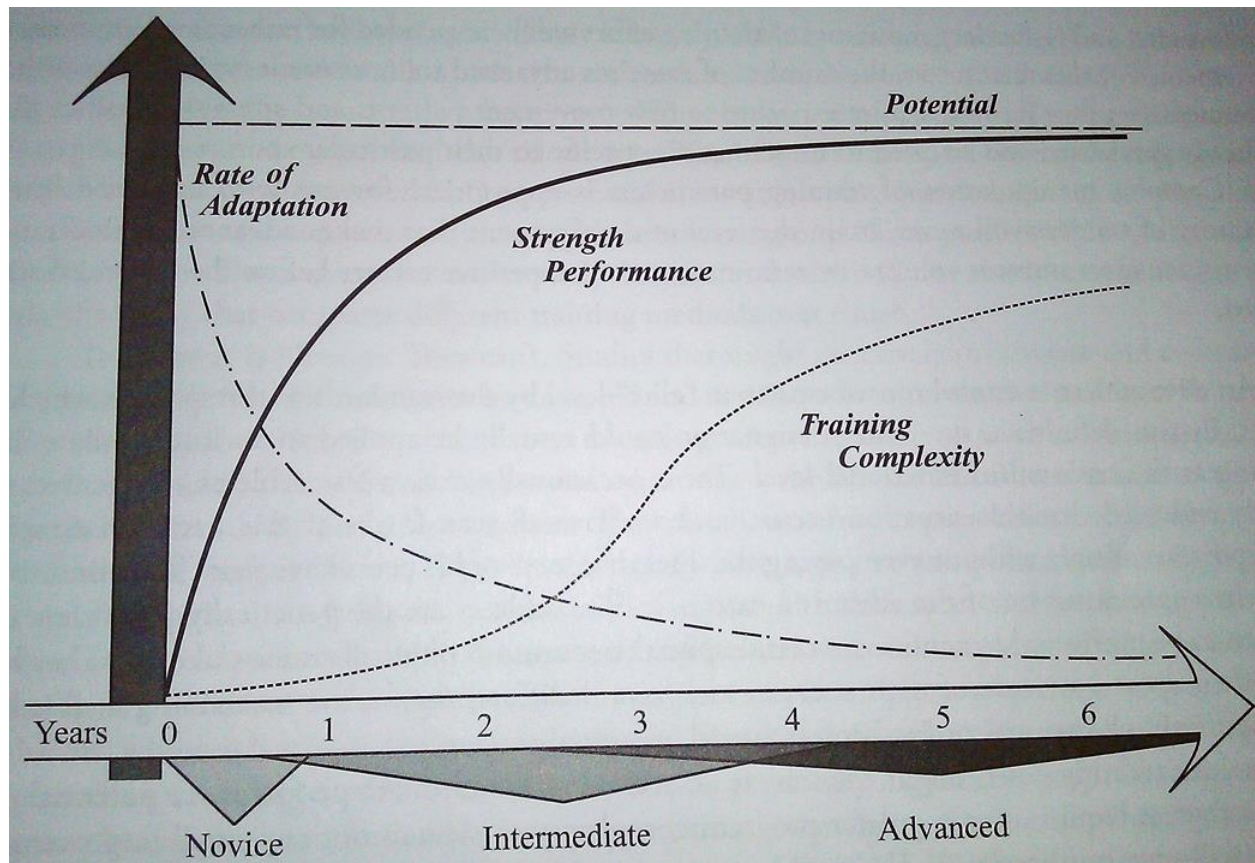
Programming is the lowest level of the three levels of zoom. Programming refers to the actual manipulation of weights, sets, and reps to generate progress. Programming is what each individual training session is made up of.

### Training Advancement and Athlete Classification

The novice requires neither specific periods of emphasis on certain qualities nor variety in programming; they perform the same workout each time.

The intermediate trainee doesn't need specific periods of emphasis on particular performance attributes, but they do need programmatic variety from microcycle to microcycle.

The advanced athlete needs BOTH periods of specific emphasis on certain qualities AND programmatic variety from microcycle to microcycle.



The more advanced you become, the slower you progress and the more complex your training gets.  
photo: Practical Programming 3rd Ed, Mark Rippetoe, 2014.

## Chapter 8: The Novice Program

### Introducing the PowerliftingToWin Novice Program (PNP)

#### What to Expect

In developing a novice program, we must ensure that each and every one of the eight items listed in the summary above is thoroughly addressed. Each item must be optimized for the novice stage of training advancement.

In order to demonstrate that this is certainly the case with the [PowerliftingToWin](#) Novice Program (PNP), first I'm going to layout the program in its entirety and then I'm going to justify its particulars. If you're familiar with the [PowerliftingToWin Programming series](#), we're going to analyze the PNP in exactly the same fashion.

## The PowerliftingToWin Novice Program (PNP) Summary

### The Actual Program

*PNP1: The "True" Novice*

| PNP1: The "True" Novice |               |                  |      |     |
|-------------------------|---------------|------------------|------|-----|
| Day                     | Exercise      | Reps             | Sets | RPE |
| Mon                     | Squat         | 3-6              | 2    | @9  |
|                         | Bench         | 3-6              | 3    | @9  |
|                         | Deadlift      | 3-6              | 1    | @9  |
| Wed                     | Squat         | 3-6              | 2    | @9  |
|                         | Bench         | 3-6              | 3    | @9  |
|                         | Deadlift      | 3-6              | 1    | @9  |
| Fri                     | Squat         | 3-6              | 2    | @9  |
|                         | Bench         | 3-6              | 3    | @9  |
|                         | Deadlift      | 3-6              | 1    | @9  |
| Sat                     | Row Exercise  | Max Reps in 7min |      |     |
|                         | Ab Exercise   | Max Reps in 7min |      |     |
|                         | Curl Exercise | Max Reps in 7min |      |     |
|                         | Conditioning  | 7 HIIT Sprints   |      |     |
|                         | Mobility      | 5-10min          |      |     |

PNP2: The "Advanced" Novice

| PNP2: The "Advanced" Novice |                     |                  |      |     |
|-----------------------------|---------------------|------------------|------|-----|
| Day                         | Exercise            | Reps             | Sets | RPE |
| Mon                         | Squat               | 3-6              | 3    | @9  |
|                             | Bench               | 3-6              | 5    | @9  |
|                             | Deadlift            | 3-6              | 2    | @9  |
| Tue                         | Row Exercise        | Max Reps in 7min |      |     |
|                             | Ab Exercise         | Max Reps in 7min |      |     |
|                             | Curl Exercise       | Max Reps in 7min |      |     |
|                             | Conditioning        | 7 HIIT Sprints   |      |     |
|                             | Mobility            | 5-10min          |      |     |
| Wed                         | 2-Count Pause Squat | 3-6              | 2    | @9  |
|                             | 2-Count Pause Bench | 3-6              | 2    | @9  |
| Fri                         | Squat               | 3-6              | 3    | @9  |
|                             | Bench               | 3-6              | 5    | @9  |
|                             | Deadlift            | 3-6              | 2    | @9  |
| Sat                         | Row Exercise        | Max Reps in 7min |      |     |
|                             | Ab Exercise         | Max Reps in 7min |      |     |
|                             | Curl Exercise       | Max Reps in 7min |      |     |
|                             | Conditioning        | 7 HIIT Sprints   |      |     |
|                             | Mobility            | 5-10min          |      |     |

| PNP3: The "Autoregulated" Novice |                     |                  |     |         |           |
|----------------------------------|---------------------|------------------|-----|---------|-----------|
| Day                              | Exercise            | Reps             | RPE | Fatigue | Method    |
| Mon                              | Squat               | 3-6              | @9  | 3-6%    | Load Drop |
|                                  | Bench               | 3-6              | @9  | 5-10%   | Load Drop |
|                                  | Deadlift            | 3-6              | @9  | 2-4%    | Load Drop |
| Tue                              | Row Exercise        | Max Reps in 7min |     |         |           |
|                                  | Ab Exercise         | Max Reps in 7min |     |         |           |
|                                  | Curl Exercise       | Max Reps in 7min |     |         |           |
|                                  | Conditioning        | 7 HIIT Sprints   |     |         |           |
|                                  | Mobility            | 5-10min          |     |         |           |
| Wed                              | 2-Count Pause Squat | 3-6              | @8  | 2-3%    | Repeat    |
|                                  | 2-Count Pause Bench | 3-6              | @8  | 2-3%    | Repeat    |
| Fri                              | Squat               | 3-6              | @9  | 3-6%    | Load Drop |
|                                  | Bench               | 3-6              | @9  | 5-10%   | Load Drop |
|                                  | Deadlift            | 3-6              | @9  | 2-4%    | Load Drop |
| Sat                              | Row Exercise        | Max Reps in 7min |     |         |           |
|                                  | Ab Exercise         | Max Reps in 7min |     |         |           |
|                                  | Curl Exercise       | Max Reps in 7min |     |         |           |
|                                  | Conditioning        | 7 HIIT Sprints   |     |         |           |
|                                  | Mobility            | 5-10min          |     |         |           |

## The Weight Progression Protocol

| PNP Weight Progression Protocol |                                |             |             |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------|-------------|-------------|
| Lowest Reps On Any Set          | Weight To Add for Next Workout |             |             |
| Squat, Bench, Deadlift          | Phase 1                        | Phase 2     | Phase 3     |
| 6 Reps                          | +10lbs/5kg                     | +5lbs/2kg   | +2.5lbs/1kg |
| 5 Reps                          | +5lbs/2kg                      | +2.5lbs/1kg | +2.5lbs/1kg |
| 4 Reps                          | +2.5lbs/1kg                    | +2.5lbs/1kg | +1lbs/0.5kg |
| 3 Reps                          | +1lbs/0.5kg                    | +1lbs/0.5kg | +1lbs/0.5kg |

## The “Stalling” Protocol:

| PNP Stalling Protocol                                                         |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Definition: <i><b>Failing to get at least three reps on all work sets</b></i> |
| Protocol                                                                      |
| <i><b>Phase 1:</b> Reset 20% and move to Phase 2</i>                          |
| <i><b>Phase 2:</b> Reset 20% and move to Phase 3</i>                          |
| <i><b>Phase 3:</b> Rest 20% and move to Intermediate Programming</i>          |

## Program Execution

### Starting Weights

Use approximately 75-80% or a weight you've done in the past for 8-10 reps. If you've never done either of those things before, work up to a weight that you can fairly easily get six reps with. The weight should still be a challenge for you to maintain proper form with. You will progress from there.

### Warm-Ups

Please consult the accompanying spreadsheet. The entire warm-up is calculated for you. If you're having issues with it, my suggested warm-up is:

#### *Warm-Up Example*

Bar x 5 reps x however many sets you need  
30% of your top set x 5 reps x 1 set  
50% of your top set x 5 reps x 1 set  
70% of your top set x 3 reps x 1 set  
80% of your top set x 2 reps x 1 set  
90% of your top set x 1 reps x 1 set, add belt and/or wrist wraps here  
Top Set x 3-6 reps x sets depend on the Phase you're in

### Rest Periods

I'd highly recommend that you stick to 3-5 minutes between sets.

### Workout Execution

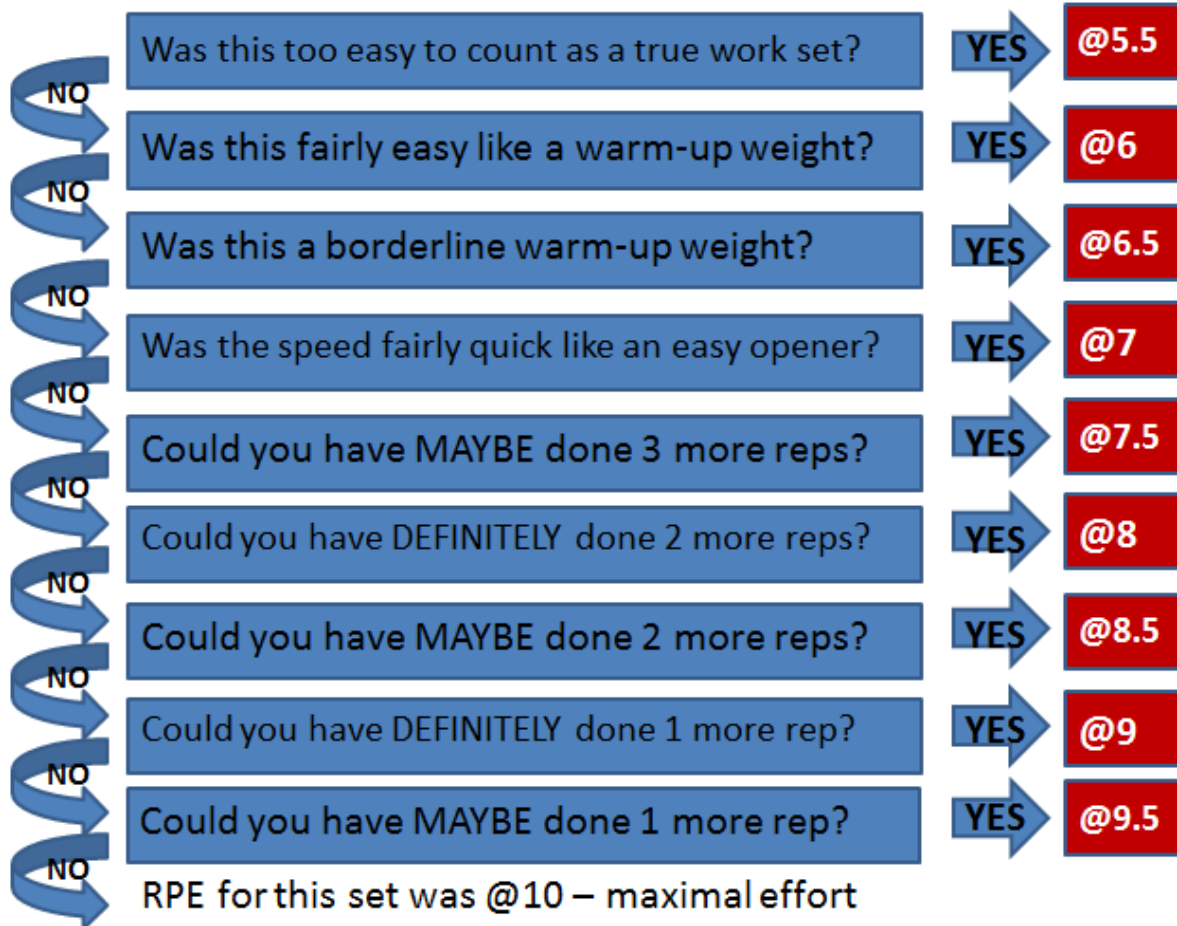
You'll notice that you're given a rep range of 3-6 reps. Your job is to get as many reps as is possible within this rep range without: a) going to failure and b) while leaving one rep in the tank. The only exception here is that if you need to go all out to get your minimum three reps on a set, that's acceptable. A stall on this program will be achieved through an actual failure NOT an "assumed failure" where you didn't even try.

For those of you with serious technique issues, that means leaving one rep with decent form in the tank. Avoid indulging in poor form to get reps.

### Recording RPE

I'd like you to try to go to RPE 9 on all of your sets. You won't get this perfectly at first and that's okay. I still want you to get in the habit of recording the RPE of all your top sets. ***You MUST record RPE!***

### RPE Scale:



### Progression Protocol

This program is a “linear” progression program. Although the weights won’t literally progress linearly, you’re going to add weight to whatever you did in your last workout based on your last performance.

*You base your increase on your worst set NOT your total reps.* This is very simple to do using the charts provided in the summary section above. Please keep in mind the spreadsheet makes these calculations for you automatically.

As an aside, in order to do this program properly, you will need microplates. *This program cannot be done without microplates.* If you need them in pounds, get these [microplates](#). If you’re in Europe or anywhere that uses the metric system, get [KG microplates](#). Like I said, if you don’t get microplates, you’re not doing my program. **PERIOD!**

### PNP1 Example

Let’s say you did 100 for 5, 4, and 3 reps on your last bench workout in PNP1. One look at the chart tells us that, in PNP1, if we get 3 reps on any set, we’re supposed to add 1lb/0.5kg.

### ***PNP2 Example***

Now, say you're in PNP2, and for your last bench workout you did 150 for 6, 6, 6, 6, and 4. We can look at the chart and see that, during PNP2, if you get 4 reps on any set, you're required to add 2.5lbs/1kg.

### ***PNP 3 Example***

If you're on PNP3, and for your last bench workout you did 200 for 6 on your top set, you'll add 2.5lbs/1kg as well. PNP3 is a little different because you only have one top set and then you do your back-off sets with the load drop. Your progression is based entirely on the top set for PNP3.

## **The Differences Between Phase 1, Phase 2, and Phase 3**

### ***PNP1:***

In PNP1, you're going to perform the same workout every time: Squat for two sets of three to six reps (2x3-6); Paused Bench for three sets of three to six reps (3x3-6); and, Deadlift for one set of three to six reps (1x3-6). It is that simple.

### ***PNP 2:***

In PNP2, the volume goes up and on Monday and Friday, you'll: Squat for three sets of three to six reps (3x3-6); Paused Bench for five sets of three to six reps (5x3-6); and, Deadlift for two sets of three to six reps (2x3-6).

We also introduce a light day on Wednesday. The Wednesday light day is going to include 2-Count Paused Squats and 2-Count Paused Benches. Each movement will be performed for two sets of three to six reps (2x3-6).

***These light day exercises are to be progressed separately from your heavy days!*** A good starting weight for these Wednesday movements is 75% of the weights you did that Monday.

### ***PNP3:***

PNP3 is where we'll begin to use nearly full autoregulation.

### ***PNP3 "Heavy Days"***

On Mondays and Fridays, on each movement, using our usual progression, you're going to work up to a single top set of three to six reps at an RPE of 9 (x3-6@9). After you've done this, you're going to subtract the indicated percentage for your "Load Drop". These are essentially back-off sets. You'll perform back-off sets until you do a back-off set that is also an RPE 9. In other words, you'll perform back-off sets until the back-offs are just as hard as the initial top set.

For example, if you squatted 300lbs for 5 reps on your top set in PNP3, you'd subtract 3-5% (aim for the middle), and wind up with 288lbs. You can use your microplates or you can just round. In this case, we'll decide to drop the weight to 285lbs.

### ***PNP3 Example "Heavy Day" Workout***

Squat:

300lbs x 5 @ 9, Initial Top Set

285lbs x 5 @ 8, Back-Off #1

285lbs x 5 @ 8.5, Back-Off #2

**285lbs x5 @ 9, Back-Off #3, STOP HERE! Fatigue reached.**

### PNP3 “Light Days”

Now, for the Wednesday workout, we’re going to use “Repeats”. You will work up to an initial weight that is an RPE 8 (three reps left in the tank). Then, once you’ve reached this weight, you will simply repeat it until it becomes an RPE 9.

### PNP3 Example “Light Day” Workout

2-Count Paused Squat

225x5@8, Initial Top Set

225x5@8

**225x5@8.5, STOP HERE!, Fatigue Reached**

### Calculating Fatigue with Repeats

| Fatigue and Repeats |            |         |
|---------------------|------------|---------|
| RPE Increase        | Example    | Fatigue |
| 0.5                 | 8.0-->8.5  | 2-3%    |
| 1                   | 8.0-->9.0  | 4-6%    |
| 1.5                 | 8.0-->9.5  | 6-9%    |
| 2                   | 8.0-->10.0 | 9-12%   |

### General Physical Preparation (GPP) Movements:

The main rules of GPP are to avoid barbells and heavy compound movements. Do NOT pick exercises that stress the lower back. We’re trying to work the muscles and not the movements on these days. Perform GPP before conditioning.

#### *GPP Protocol:*

Pick a weight that you can get 8-12 reps on the first set. Don’t go to failure. Go to RPE 7 or 8 (two to three reps left). Rest 20-45sec and then do another set at RPE 7-8. You won’t get as many as the first set. That’s okay. Wait another 20-45sec and do it again. Repeat this process for the total time listed and try to get as many reps as possible whilst avoiding going to failure. Use a weight that allows for a total of 45-65 reps or so.

**Row Exercise:** Chest-supported row, DB Row, Cable Row, Pullups, and Lat Pulldowns are all great options here.

**Ab Exercise:** Situps, decline situps, the ab wheel, and many other good options exist here.

**Curl Exercise:** Pick a DB or machine curl variation. My favorite is the hammer curl for elbow health.

### **Conditioning:**

Perform conditioning after GPP.

### **Conditioning Protocol:**

Warm-Up: 5 minutes

Conditioning: Prescribed Number of ~20 second ALL OUT “sprints”, 100 seconds between efforts

Cool Down: 10 minute cool down

### **Acceptable Forms of Conditioning**

You can use an elliptical, an exercise bike, a sled, a prowler, a C2 Rower or any other equipment that offers resistance to do these sprints. You should be limited by your muscles and NOT your lungs. Use enough resistance that your speed that is slower than a true sprint but faster than a jog.



Nothing beats pushing the Prowler in my book.  
photo: elitefts.com

### **Mobility:**

If you have any muscles that are sore or stiff, stretch them out. If you have anything that bothers you during your training, try to improve your flexibility/mobility at that point.

I often use this time to stretch my shoulders and my hips. Stretching my hips lets me better utilize the sumo deadlift and a wide stance squat. I also highly recommend shoulder dislocations for overall shoulder health and for being able to take a narrower squat grip. Trying to develop your bench press arch is also a useful way to spend this time.



The banded shoulder dislocation is one of my favorite upperbody mobility movements.

## Novice Program Explanation and Analysis:

### Planning

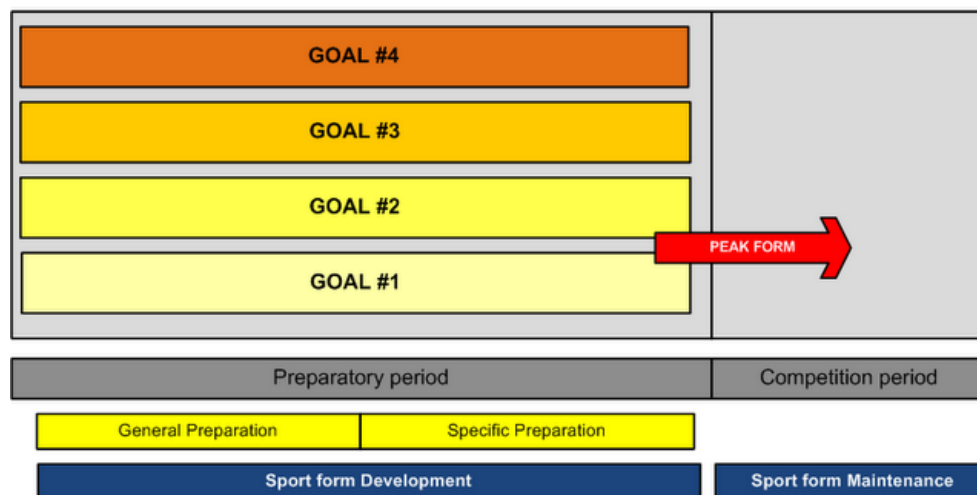
As far as planning, I highly encourage novices to compete in meets early and often. If you wish to compete in a meet using this program, regardless of your Phase, all you have to do is skip your Friday workout and compete on Saturday/Sunday. There is no need for a peak because, remember, the novice is fully recovered by the time the next workout rolls around. An extra day of rest is more than enough to leave you prepared for the meet.

### Periodization

As discussed previously, a novice is capable of setting a PR each and every time they step into the gym. They don't need programmatic variation nor do they need periods of specific emphasis on different performance attributes. As such, Phase 1 of this program features neither. You'll be performing the same workout every single time because you'll be expected to set a PR each time you go into the gym (for the most part). In other words, you'll have already gone through the full stress-recovery-adaptation cycle before each workout and there just isn't any need for complexity.

In terms of Periodization, every single Phase makes use of Complex-Parallel Periodization. There is no need for even the "advanced" novice, to attempt to separate his training out into different blocks and periods of specific emphasis. Even the advanced novice can still improve upon strength, technique, and hypertrophy simultaneously. That is exactly what we ask them to do in all three Phases of PNP.

## COMPLEX-PARALLEL TRAINING



Complex-Parallel Periodization Example  
photo: [complementarytraining.blogspot.com](http://complementarytraining.blogspot.com)

## Programming

Now programmatic variation does start to be incorporated after PNP1. In PNP2 and PNP3, a light day is introduced. This is to account for the increased recovery needs of the more “advanced” novice. We’ll discuss this more in fatigue management.

### *Programming in PNP2*

Of more importance here, when discussing programming, is that the volume is increased during PNP2. The reason for this has to do with the fact that, as you become more and more advanced as a trainee, you have to do more and more volume to keep progressing. That is why volume is increased from two sets to three on the squat, from three sets to five on the bench, and from one set to two on the deadlift.

Remember the sun tan analogy? You can’t keep using 15 minute sessions forever if you want to make progress. In combination with the light day, we can both increase the overall volume for advanced novices AND give them a better recovery structure throughout the week.

### *Programming in PNP3*

Now, in PNP3, the overall volume and intensity of the program is tinkered with in a major way. I’ll get more into autoregulation when we analyze individual differences, but the point is that the first two Phases prepare the lifter for the third, and final, autoregulated phase by teaching them RPE, establishing decent work capacity, and a base level of volume tolerance. In PNP3, volume is no longer cookie cutter, but rather determined by individual needs. Additionally, because you’re only required to do one top set, you’ll be able to push your linear progression that much further. This is the final programmatic adjustment that allows linear progression to be continued: back-off sets. That is why back-offs are added last, in terms of the phases, and controlled via autoregulation.

## Specificity

### *PNP and Powerlifting Specificity*

To my knowledge, PNP is the only novice program out there that is explicitly designed for the purposes of powerlifting. Every other novice program is designed for hypertrophy, general strength, bodybuilding, or some other purpose. If you’re interested in powerlifting, it is critical to pick a program that was actually made with your goals in mind. Because this is strictly a powerlifting program, there is no overhead pressing, rowing, or power cleaning that is so typical of these other novice programs.

### *Overhead Pressing*

The reason for this is quite simple: specificity. It has been my personal experience that overhead press, being less specific than the bench press, has a far lower rate of transference to increasing the bench press than... doing more bench pressing. It isn’t that the overhead press isn’t a great exercise because it absolutely is. For powerlifters though, the bench press is the best exercise to drive the bench press. As such, you’ll be doing lots of heavy bench pressing.

### Paused Benching

Likewise, this is the reason all bench pressing is done paused rather than with touch and go technique. In powerlifting competition, you have to pause your bench presses. Ask yourself a very simple question. If you have to pause your bench press in competition, what is more specific: the touch and go bench press or the paused bench press? The question answers itself.

### Barbell Rows

Regarding barbell rows, again, it isn't that barbell rows aren't a great exercise because they are. However, rows are also quite taxing on the lower back. As a powerlifter, who is primarily interested in a big deadlift, would you rather spend your lower back recovery resources on rowing or deadlifting? Which is more specific? What might have a higher rate of transference to your total? Instead of doing barbell rows, on this program we save that lower back recovery and just do more deadlifts instead.

### Squat vs. Deadlift Volume

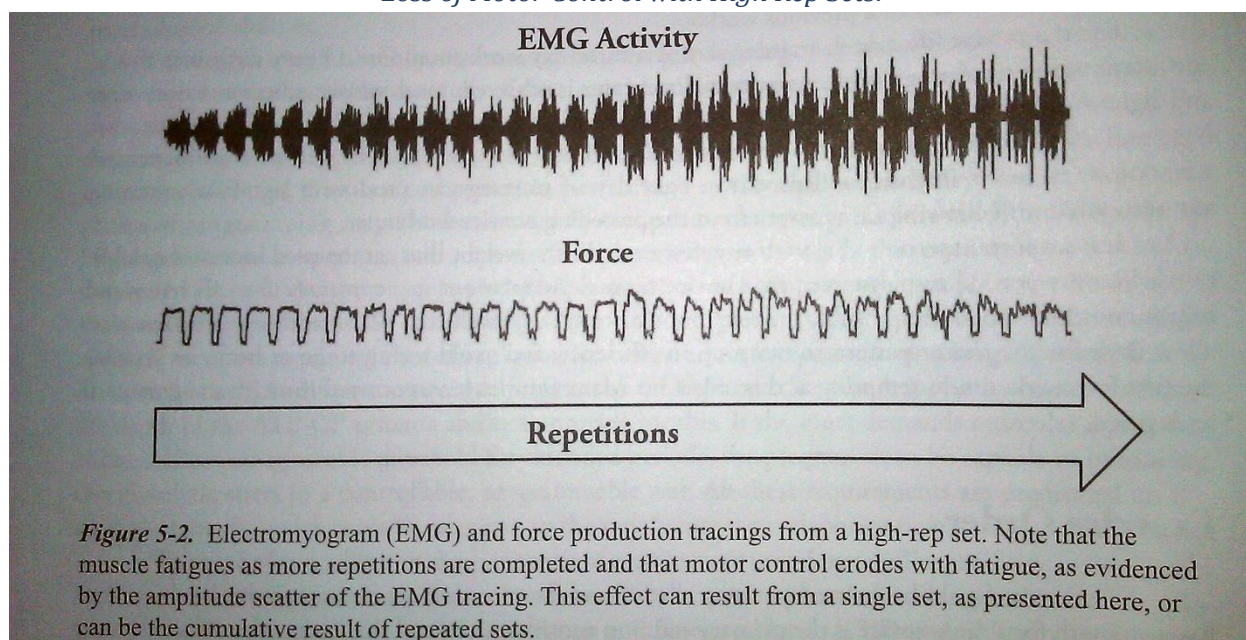
The last gripe I have with general strength programs is the overemphasis of the squat compared to the deadlift. In Powerlifting, using **very general estimates** (*please do not read into this too much!*) the squat will make up 35% of the total, the bench will make up 25% of the total, and the deadlift will make up 40% of the total. Considering that, in some senses, the deadlift is the most important lift, why would you want to do one set of deadlifts for every five to ten sets of squats that you do? That just doesn't make sense.

Yes, it is true that the squat drives the deadlift more than the deadlift drives the squat, but training economy only takes you so far. If you want to be a good deadlifter, you need to do a healthy volume of deadlifts. As such, this program features a MUCH more equitable balance between the squat and the deadlift. Meets are often won on the final deadlift. Make sure your pull doesn't suck by actually training the movement.

### Rep Range

Perhaps most importantly, the rep range extends a bit beyond merely having you do endless sets of five. However, the reps are capped at six for two reasons: 1) above six reps, the intensity continuum starts to emphasize hypertrophy over strength and 2) above six reps, fatigue starts to cause deterioration in technique as the set progresses. Technique is of paramount importance in powerlifting. Whereas other sporting athletes can get away with some slop in their technique during lifting, the powerlifter can't. Your technique on the three lifts IS your sport. Any inefficiency decreases your potential on the platform. We don't want to engrain poor motor habits through sloppy, high rep sets.

### *Loss of Motor Control with High Rep Sets:*



You can see the progressive deterioration in motor control as the reps increase.  
Photograph: [Practical Programming 3rd Ed](#), Mark Rippetoe, Aasgaard Co., 2014.

That said, unlike most other novice programs, you're going to get exposure to heavy triples at some point during each training cycle. This will better prepare you for the realities of a powerlifting meet where you're going to be required to lift very heavy weights for a single rep. Triples are simply more specific than sets of five for powerlifting.

### **PNP Is The Most Specific Powerlifting Program Available for Novices**

When you consider the frequency with which you perform the powerlifts on this program, and the fact you always perform them in the same order as you do in competition, it is easy to see why this program is far and away the most specific novice powerlifting program available.

### ***The Point of GPP, Conditioning and Mobility***

Now, I'm sure a lot of you are going to question the inclusion of GPP, Conditioning, and Mobility work after that long rant about the importance of specificity.

Now, while it is true that GPP, by its very nature, is "general" physical preparation, there is a minimum of work outside of the powerlifts that must be done to help promote recovery, health, and hypertrophy.

### **GPP, Health, and Hypertrophy**

While I am neither a believer nor a disbeliever in the idea that you must do rowing if you're going to bench and keep your shoulders healthy, there is no doubt that it does help some people (I suspect for most that it doesn't). Additionally, while, again, I think muscular imbalances are grossly over-diagnosed on the internet, keeping some pulling work in the program helps prevent any of these issues. As such, rows and curls are included to keep our shoulders and elbows healthy, provide a hypertrophy stimulus

to these “neglected” muscles, and to provide us with a good nutrient partitioning stimulus on days that we normally wouldn’t receive any training effect.

### Why We Do Conditioning

As far as conditioning goes, I believe this to be of critical importance for a variety of reasons. Powerlifters are notorious for taking forever between sets. This is all well and good, but, in the real world, we all have time limits for how long we can be in the gym. Because we know that volume must continually increase over time for us to make progress, and because our time limits for the gym generally do not increase with these volume needs, we have to fit more and more volume into a shorter period of time. By including frequent conditioning we improve our “work capacity” which allows us to recover more easily and more quickly between sets, exercises, and workouts. Our body becomes more efficient at processing the various metabolic “waste” that is produced during hard anaerobic exercise. As we advanced into our training career, we’ll already have developed the necessary work capacity to handle these increased volumes without needing more overall time in the gym. The shorter rest periods won’t affect us.

Additionally, conditioning provides a powerful nutrient partitioning stimulus. Not only are you going to burn quite a bit of fat after performing HIIT, but the carbs you eat before and after your sessions are more likely to be partitioned towards muscle cells. While I will not be discussing [nutrition](#) in this book, it must be said that being lean is a critical component of actually being competitive in today’s lifting climate. Records and placing go to the leaner athletes who are more capable of fitting into lighter weight classes without having to sacrifice any of their muscle mass.

### The Point of Mobility Work

As far as mobility, again, I think there is currently a trend on the internet to completely overprescribe mobility drills and exercises, but there is also no doubt that a complete neglect of this aspect of performance is detrimental.

By spending a minimal amount of time on mobility, you can improve your positioning on all three of the lifts. If you can improve your hip mobility and take a wider stance on your sumo deadlift or squat, that is going to add to your total. If you can improve your arch on the bench press, you don’t have to move the bar as far and that will add to your total.

And, as some people would suggest, keeping a basic level of mobility will prevent injury which is the single biggest reason for lack of progress beyond the intermediate level of training advancement. As such, you’ll be performing at least 5-10 minutes of basic mobility one to two times per week depending on your training advancement. Your goal is not to become the next “[Supple Leopard](#)”; your goal is maintain basic functional movement and overall health.

### Overload

One of the most unique aspects of this program is the overload protocol. Most novice programs feature one of two progression protocols: linear progression or double progression.

### *Linear Progression (LP) and Double Progression (DP)*

Linear progression is the process by which a fixed increment, such as 5lbs, is added to the bar every single workout. Double progression is the process by which a lifter works in a rep range and only increases the weight once they've maxed out their rep range. For example, they might be prescribed four sets of 8-12 reps. Once they can do 12 reps on all four sets, they'd then add weight.

### *Simultaneous Double Progression vs. LP and DP*

In PNP, we combine these concepts and use what I'll call "Simultaneous Double Progression".

Simultaneous double progression is superior to linear progression because you are not limited by a fixed increment. Sometimes you are capable of not only adding weight, but also adding reps. If you have a fixed rep range and a fixed increment to work with, you cannot take advantage of these days.

With double progression, especially as you get stronger, it can often be very, very hard to add a single rep. Just for example, if you're using a one rep max calculator, adding a rep generally corresponds to a 2-3% increase of your one rep max. If you're trying to do that three times per week, you're increasing your one rep max something like 6-9% per week. That is completely unsustainable.

With simultaneous double progression, even if you can't add a full rep, you can still usually add 1-2lbs/0.5-1kg because this is usually less than 1% of your one rep max. Simultaneous double progression retains the advantages of both protocols while eliminating several weaknesses.

### *EARN Your Progress*

Now, I know a lot of you are going to claim that my progression increments are far too small. Well, if that's true, go and out prove it! If you want to take bigger jumps, you're allowed to do so. All you have to do is fill out those rep ranges consistently and you'll EARN the bigger jumps. That is the best aspect of this entire program: motivated individuals will EARN superior rates of progress versus their less dedicated peers.

## **Fatigue Management**

### *The "True" Novice*

As far as fatigue management, in PNP1, the novice is given 48 hours to recover between all heavy workouts with the exception of the weekend. Theoretically, you could make more progress by lifting every other day, but most people will find it much easier to stick to a weekly schedule rather than lifting on different days each week. It is no coincidence that the GPP day is placed on Saturday. This way, you still have a full 48 hours off before your Monday workout. This minimizes the chances of GPP getting in the way.

In the simplest terms, a novice doesn't need much fatigue management. We must make sure they are doing enough volume to make progress, but, at the same time, make sure they're not doing so much that they can't recover in time for the next workout. Novices are highly adaptable and this isn't

particularly challenging. For this reason, and other reasons discussed above, all the workouts have the same amount of volume.

### *The “Advanced” Novice*

Passed the very earliest stages of novice training, most people won’t be able to recover in 48 hours anymore. They’ll start to need 72 hours or more. In PNP2 and PNP3, we introduce a light day into the middle of the week. By making Wednesday a “light” day, we allow for this extra recovery without any detraining in the middle of the week due to an extended rest period. This way the “Advanced” Novices can still set PRs twice a week which is appropriate for their training advancement.

### *Understanding “Light Day”*

This “light” effect is achieved through the use of reduced volume as well as exercise selection that promotes lower absolute intensities. Instead of doing five total sets of upper and lower body respectively, as we do on Monday and Friday, we perform only two total sets for each. Also, by making use of extended pauses, we cannot use as much weight as we usually can. Additionally, as a bonus, the pause movements are excellent for teaching proper technique and preventing Wednesday from feeling like a “pointless” workout where you don’t lift anything meaningful. All of these factors help us get a good training session in on Wednesdays while still allowing for far more recovery throughout the overall training week. In this manner, we can extend the novice phase longer than we otherwise could.

## **Individual Differences**

### *Why PNP1 and PNP2 Aren’t Fully Autoregulated*

Now, the obvious problem with Phases 1 and 2 of PNP is that they aren’t fully autoregulated. There is a good reason for this. Novices simply aren’t capable of accurately rating RPE – at least initially. This one of the primary reasons a rep range is chosen rather than a fixed increment. By allowing novices to work in a rep range, they begin to learn their limits. During each and every set, they’ll be forced to try and “feel out” how many reps they have left. By practicing this during every single workout, their ability to judge the difficulty of a set improves at an exponential pace.

Because they’re also recording the RPEs of every set, they will begin to build the habit and the skill of being able to accurately rate RPE. This will allow us to use autoregulation much sooner in our training careers than we otherwise could. Most people take ten years to learn to “listen to their body”. This program will teach you to do it in 3-6 months.

### *Autoregulation in PNP1 and PNP2*

That said, the first two phases of the program DO contain a great degree of autoregulation compared to other novice programs.

### *Rep Ranges*

While rep ranges aren’t a perfect autoregulatory protocol, we do give the novice some room for good days and bad days. On good days, they’ll smash all their reps and be able to earn a larger jump. On bad days, they might underperform. However, because they’re operating in a rep range, that bad day won’t

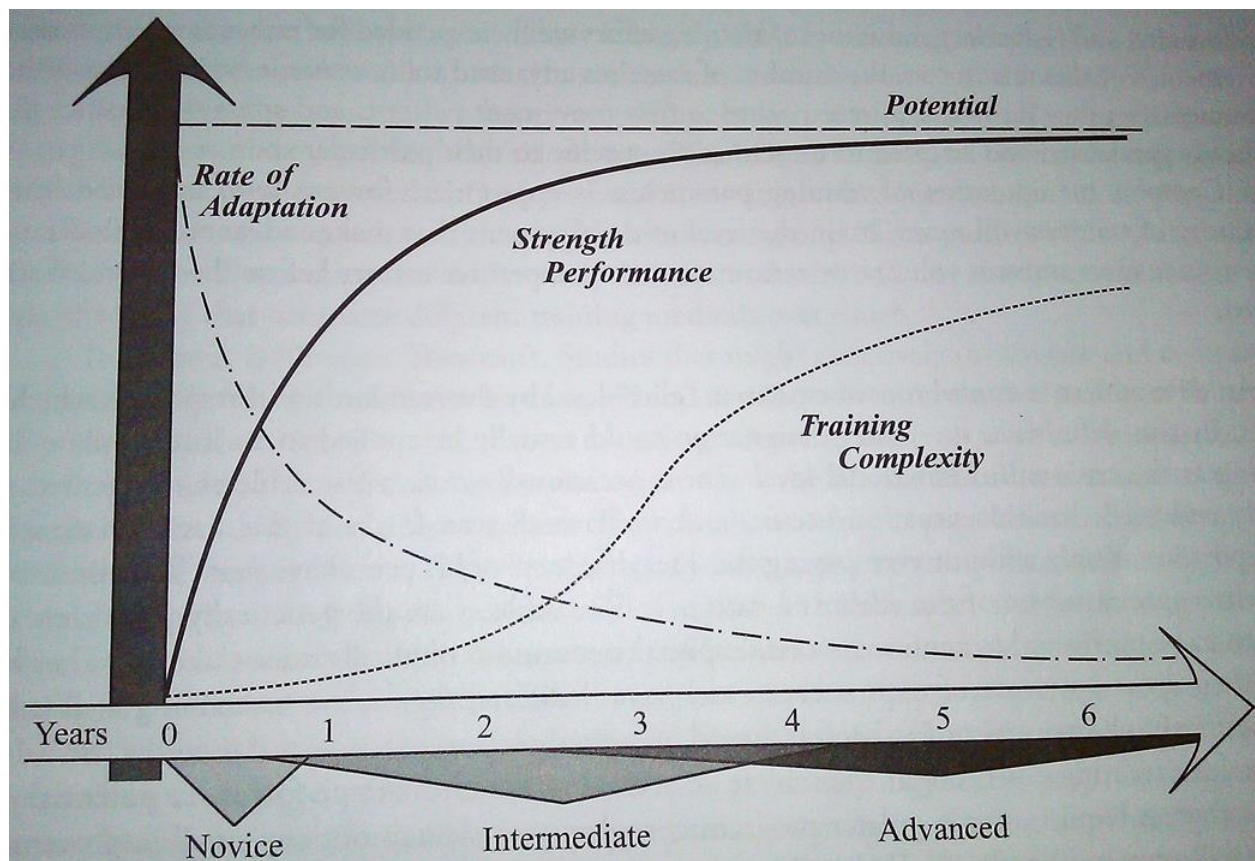
cause a “failure” or a “stall”. It is just a bad day. They can regroup the next workout after a very small jump in weight and try to get back to their usual level of performance. In other words, this program isn’t going to cause missed reps and failures every time someone has a bad day for whatever reason.

### Simultaneous Double Progression

Likewise, the rate of progression is autoregulated to a large degree. It is a fact that novices do not all progress at the same rate. So why should we try to force all of them to use the same fixed increments of progress?

PNP does NOT do this! If you’re capable of fast progress, you will make that fast progress because you’ll constantly be getting into the higher part of the rep range and earning bigger jumps. Likewise, if you need slower progression for whatever reason, you’ll get that too because you won’t be easily filling out the rep range.

Additionally, this allows for faster progress at the beginning of your progression and slower progression towards the end. Look, linear progression is a bit of a farce. The progress curve in strength training resembles more closely that of exponential decay than any sort of a linear relationship. Your strength increases at a decreasing rate. The progression protocol here accounts for that fact. Most other programs don’t.



As training advancement increases, the rate of adaptation decreases as well.  
photo: [Practical Programming](#) 3rd Ed, Mark Rippetoe, Aasgaard Co., 2014.

### *Autoregulation in PNP3*

Now, of course, by PNP3, the program is nearly fully autoregulated. We still have a restriction on the intensity autoregulation to force the novice to continue to make linear progress twice a week, but the volume is fully autoregulated at this point. However much volume is necessary for that individual to reach the desired fatigue is the amount of volume they'll perform.

The most important part of all of this is that by learning autoregulation as a novice, we set up our athletes for a very smooth transition into intermediate training. I am not exaggerating when I suggest that this process will cut years off the novice's learning curve. Had I followed this exact protocol myself, I believe I could have achieved the same strength levels I now possess in half the time or less. I expect fairly similar results for those who decide to see the PNP through to the end of all three phases.

## Chapter 8: The PowerliftingToWin Intermediate Program

### Introducing The PowerliftingToWin Intermediate Program (PIP)

#### The Novice Phase Eventually Ends

Regardless of how well you handle your programming, recovery, and nutrition, eventually, intermediate programming becomes necessary. Luckily, with PNP you've been getting readied for intermediate programming for months. Not only can you now handle a fairly substantial amount of volume in a single session due to PNP2 and PNP3, but you can also complete a fairly highly volume workout in a reasonable time due to intelligent management of rest periods and the inclusion of twice weekly HIIT conditioning. Further still, you're ready to begin autoregulation immediately, which puts you at a huge advantage over other intermediate trainees.

But what if you didn't do PNP?

### Are You An Intermediate Trainee?

#### Go Back to PNP3

If you're arriving at this point having completed another novice program, I would actually encourage you to take a step back and complete PNP3.

Why? Well, even if this phase only lasts you a few months, in PNP3, you'll at least begin to become adapted to training five times a week, doing regular conditioning work, performing all three lifts in the same session, and, most importantly, using autoregulation. All of these things will put you in a better position when you finally do try the intermediate program. And hey, who knows, maybe the combined use of autoregulation and a single top set will allow you to take your novice progression much further than you ever did with 3x5 or 5x5 style programming.

#### Rehashing Novice vs. Intermediate vs. Advanced

It must also be added that one of the most common questions I receive is some permutation of the following question: "Am I Novice, Intermediate, or an Advanced Trainee"? As discussed in the trainee classification session of this book, we can only answer this question in terms of what type of programming and periodization are necessary for you to make progress.

### Visualizing Novice vs. Intermediate vs. Advanced

| Theoretical Examples |                |                |                |
|----------------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|
| Novice               | Mesocycle 1    | Mesocycle 2    | Mesocycle 3    |
| Periodization Focus  | All Attributes | All Attributes | All Attributes |
| Programming          | Static         | Static         | Static         |

| Intermediate        | Mesocycle 1                   | Mesocycle 2                  | Mesocycle 3                   |
|---------------------|-------------------------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| Periodization Focus | All Attributes                | All Attributes               | All Attributes                |
| Programming         | High Volume, Medium Intensity | Low Volume, Medium Intensity | Medium Volume, High Intensity |

| Advanced            | Mesocycle 1                   | Mesocycle 2                  | Mesocycle 3                   |
|---------------------|-------------------------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| Periodization Focus | Hypertrophy                   | Speed                        | Strength                      |
| Programming         | High Volume, Medium Intensity | Low Volume, Medium Intensity | Medium Volume, High Intensity |

If you need neither significant programmatic variety nor specific periods of emphasis on particular muscular qualities, you're a novice. If you don't need specific periods of emphasis, but you DO need programmatic variety, you're an intermediate.

#### How Do I Know “For Sure” What Type of Trainee I Am?

Now, practically speaking, the more important question is: “How do I determine what periodization and programming combo would work for me”?

The only real answer here is that *you have to advance through the programmatic continuum and determine through failures and stalls that a certain combination doesn't work for you anymore.*

That is, because we can't judge whether you're a novice from your training numbers or how long you've been training, the only true, 100% accurate way to know you're not a novice is if you've tried to make gains on a novice program and, despite having great nutrition and recovery, you simply can't do it anymore.

#### Again, Do PNP3 First

As such, my advice to take a step back comes from the framework that, while you may have completed another novice program, I personally believe that the PNP, and in particular PNP3, will allow any individual interested in powerlifting to get more out of their novice phase on the Big Three than any other program. Most importantly, if you finish PNP3, we can be absolutely certain that you're ready for intermediate programming.

If you jump straight into intermediate programming, well, you might waste many months of easier gains due to impatience. This is really a risk:reward calculation we're dealing with. There is a risk you may waste some time, in terms of overall progress, by trying PNP3, but the potential rewards are just so much higher. You might make significant progress above and beyond your last attempt at novice programming and, even if you don't, you'll become conditioned to the higher frequency and you'll learn autoregulation in the process. I think that the odds of this particular gamble are clearly in your favor.

## **Moving Forward**

With that said, we're going to follow the same format that we used with the PNP. First, I'm going to lay out the PIP in its entirety and explain how to actually do the program. Then, we're going to analyze the program to understand why it is constructed the way that it is. We'll use the same framework that was used in the [Program Review Series](#).

## The PowerliftingToWin Intermediate Program Summary

*PIP1: The "Transitioning" Intermediate*

| <b>PIP1: The "Transitioning" Intermediate</b> |                     |                  |            |                |               |
|-----------------------------------------------|---------------------|------------------|------------|----------------|---------------|
| <b>Day</b>                                    | <b>Exercise</b>     | <b>Reps</b>      | <b>RPE</b> | <b>Fatigue</b> | <b>Method</b> |
| <b>Mon</b>                                    | 2-Count Pause Squat | 4-6              | @9         | 6-9%           | Load Drop     |
|                                               | 2-Count Pause Bench | 4-6              | @9         | 6-9%           | Load Drop     |
|                                               | 2" Deficit Deadlift | 4-6              | @9         | 4-6%           | Load Drop     |
|                                               | Closegrip Bench     | 4-6              | @9         | 4-6%           | Load Drop     |
| <b>Tue</b>                                    | Row Exercise        | Max Reps in 7min |            |                |               |
|                                               | Ab Exercise         | Max Reps in 7min |            |                |               |
|                                               | Curl Exercise       | Max Reps in 7min |            |                |               |
|                                               | Conditioning        | 7 HIIT Sprints   |            |                |               |
|                                               | Mobility            | 5-10min          |            |                |               |
| <b>Wed</b>                                    | Front Squat         | 6-8              | @7         | 4-6%           | Repeat        |
|                                               | Incline Bench       | 6-8              | @7         | 4-6%           | Repeat        |
| <b>Fri</b>                                    | Squat               | 1-3              | @9         | 2-3%           | Load Drop     |
|                                               | Bench               | 1-3              | @9         | 4-6%           | Load Drop     |
|                                               | Deadlift            | 1-3              | @9         | 2-3%           | Load Drop     |
| <b>Sat</b>                                    | Row Exercise        | Max Reps in 7min |            |                |               |
|                                               | Ab Exercise         | Max Reps in 7min |            |                |               |
|                                               | Curl Exercise       | Max Reps in 7min |            |                |               |
|                                               | Conditioning        | 7 HIIT Sprints   |            |                |               |
|                                               | Mobility            | 5-10min          |            |                |               |

PIP2: The "Fully Autoregulated" Intermediate

| PIP2: The "Fully Autoregulated" Intermediate |                     |                  |        |        |     |         |           |
|----------------------------------------------|---------------------|------------------|--------|--------|-----|---------|-----------|
| Day                                          | Exercise            | Reps             |        |        | RPE | Fatigue | Method    |
|                                              |                     | Week 1           | Week 2 | Week 3 |     |         |           |
| Mon                                          | 2-Count Pause Squat | 6                | 5      | 4      | @9  | 6-9%    | Load Drop |
|                                              | 2-Count Pause Bench | 6                | 5      | 4      | @9  | 6-9%    | Load Drop |
|                                              | Incline Bench       | 8                | 7      | 6      | @8  | 4-6%    | Repeat    |
| Tue                                          | 2" Deficit Deadlift | 6                | 5      | 4      | @9  | 6-9%    | Load Drop |
|                                              | Closegrip Bench     | 6                | 5      | 4      | @9  | 6-9%    | Load Drop |
|                                              | Front Squat         | 8                | 7      | 6      | @8  | 4-6%    | Repeat    |
| Wed                                          | Row Exercise        | Max Reps in 7min |        |        |     |         |           |
|                                              | Ab Exercise         | Max Reps in 7min |        |        |     |         |           |
|                                              | Curl Exercise       | Max Reps in 7min |        |        |     |         |           |
|                                              | Conditioning        | 7 HIIT Sprints   |        |        |     |         |           |
|                                              | Mobility            | 5-10min          |        |        |     |         |           |
| Fri                                          | Squat               | 3                | 2      | 1      | @9  | 2-3%    | Load Drop |
|                                              | Paused Bench        | 3                | 2      | 1      | @9  | 2-3%    | Load Drop |
|                                              | Overhead Press      | 8                | 7      | 6      | @8  | 4-6%    | Repeat    |
| Sat                                          | Deadlift            | 3                | 2      | 1      | @9  | 2-3%    | Load Drop |
|                                              | TnG Bench           | 3                | 2      | 1      | @9  | 2-3%    | Load Drop |
|                                              | 2" Deficit SLDL     | 8                | 7      | 6      | @8  | 4-6%    | Repeat    |
| Sun                                          | Row Exercise        | Max Reps in 7min |        |        |     |         |           |
|                                              | Ab Exercise         | Max Reps in 7min |        |        |     |         |           |
|                                              | Curl Exercise       | Max Reps in 7min |        |        |     |         |           |
|                                              | Conditioning        | 7 HIIT Sprints   |        |        |     |         |           |
|                                              | Mobility            | 5-10min          |        |        |     |         |           |

*PIP3: The "Advanced" Intermediate*

| PIP3: The "Advanced" Intermediate |                     |                   |     |      |           |                  |     |      |           |                   |     |      |           |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------|-------------------|-----|------|-----------|------------------|-----|------|-----------|-------------------|-----|------|-----------|
| Day                               | Exercise            | Week 1: Volume    |     |      |           | Week 2: Recovery |     |      |           | Week 3: Intensity |     |      |           |
|                                   |                     | Reps              | RPE | FP%  | Type      | Reps             | RPE | FP%  | Type      | Reps              | RPE | FP%  | Type      |
| Mon                               | 2-Count Pause Squat | 6                 | @9  | 6-9% | Load Drop | 5                | @9  | 4-6% | Load Drop | 4                 | @9  | 6-9% | Load Drop |
|                                   | 2-Count Pause Bench | 6                 | @9  | 6-9% | Load Drop | 5                | @9  | 4-6% | Load Drop | 4                 | @9  | 6-9% | Load Drop |
|                                   | Incline Bench       | 8                 | @8  | 6-9% | Repeat    |                  |     |      |           | 6                 | @8  | 4-6% | Repeat    |
| Tue                               | 2" Deficit Deadlift | 6                 | @9  | 6-9% | Load Drop | 5                | @9  | 4-6% | Load Drop | 4                 | @9  | 6-9% | Load Drop |
|                                   | Closegrip Bench     | 6                 | @9  | 6-9% | Load Drop | 5                | @9  | 4-6% | Load Drop | 4                 | @9  | 6-9% | Load Drop |
|                                   | Front Squat         | 8                 | @8  | 6-9% | Repeat    |                  |     |      |           | 6                 | @8  | 4-6% | Repeat    |
| Wed                               | Row Exercise        | Max Reps in 10min |     |      |           | Max Reps in 5min |     |      |           | Max Reps in 7min  |     |      |           |
|                                   | Ab Exercise         | Max Reps in 10min |     |      |           | Max Reps in 5min |     |      |           | Max Reps in 7min  |     |      |           |
|                                   | Curl Exercise       | Max Reps in 10min |     |      |           | Max Reps in 5min |     |      |           | Max Reps in 7min  |     |      |           |
|                                   | Conditioning        | 10 HIIT Sprints   |     |      |           | 5 HIIT Sprints   |     |      |           | 7 HIIT Sprints    |     |      |           |
|                                   | Mobility            | 5-10min           |     |      |           | 5-10min          |     |      |           | 5-10min           |     |      |           |
| Fri                               | Squat               | 3                 | @9  | 6-9% | Load Drop | 2                | @9  | 2-3% | Load Drop | 1                 | @9  | 2-3% | Load Drop |
|                                   | Paused Bench        | 3                 | @9  | 6-9% | Load Drop | 2                | @9  | 2-3% | Load Drop | 1                 | @9  | 2-3% | Load Drop |
|                                   | Overhead Press      | 8                 | @8  | 6-9% | Repeat    |                  |     |      |           | 6                 | @8  | 4-6% | Repeat    |
| Sat                               | Deadlift            | 3                 | @9  | 6-9% | Load Drop | 2                | @9  | 2-3% | Load Drop | 1                 | @9  | 2-3% | Load Drop |
|                                   | TnG Bench           | 3                 | @9  | 6-9% | Load Drop | 2                | @9  | 2-3% | Load Drop | 1                 | @9  | 2-3% | Load Drop |
|                                   | 2" Deficit SLDL     | 8                 | @8  | 6-9% | Repeat    |                  |     |      |           | 6                 | @8  | 4-6% | Repeat    |
| Sun                               | Row Exercise        | Max Reps in 10min |     |      |           | Max Reps in 5min |     |      |           | Max Reps in 7min  |     |      |           |
|                                   | Ab Exercise         | Max Reps in 10min |     |      |           | Max Reps in 5min |     |      |           | Max Reps in 7min  |     |      |           |
|                                   | Curl Exercise       | Max Reps in 10min |     |      |           | Max Reps in 5min |     |      |           | Max Reps in 7min  |     |      |           |
|                                   | Conditioning        | 10 HIIT Sprints   |     |      |           | 5 HIIT Sprints   |     |      |           | 7 HIIT Sprints    |     |      |           |
|                                   | Mobility            | 5-10min           |     |      |           | 5-10min          |     |      |           | 5-10min           |     |      |           |

## The Weight Progression Protocol:

### PIP1

| PIP1 Weight Progression Protocol                                                |                                |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| Lowest Reps On Any Set                                                          | Weight To Add for Next Workout |
| <b>Squat, Bench, Deadlift</b>                                                   |                                |
| 3 Reps                                                                          | +5lbs/2kg                      |
| 2 Reps                                                                          | +2.5lbs/1.0kg                  |
| 1 Rep                                                                           | +1lbs/0.5kg                    |
| <b>2-Count Squat, 2-Count Pause Bench, 2" Deficit Deadlift, Closegrip Bench</b> |                                |
| 6 Reps                                                                          | +5lbs/2kg                      |
| 5 Reps                                                                          | +2.5lbs/1.0kg                  |
| 4 Reps                                                                          | +1lbs/0.5kg                    |
| <b>Front Squat, Incline Bench</b>                                               |                                |
| 8 Reps                                                                          | +5lbs/2kg                      |
| 7 Reps                                                                          | +2.5lbs/1.0kg                  |
| 6 Reps                                                                          | +1lbs/0.5kg                    |

### PIP2 and PIP3:

Based upon your last workout, use the RPE Chart to calculate an estimated one rep max (e1RM). For your next workout, calculate a work set that would result in a 1-5lbs/0.5kg-2.5kg PR.

|     | 1    | 2   | 3   | 4   | 5   | 6   | 7   | 8   | 9   | 10  |
|-----|------|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|
| 10  | 100% | 96% | 92% | 89% | 86% | 84% | 81% | 79% | 76% | 74% |
| 9.5 | 98%  | 94% | 91% | 88% | 85% | 82% | 80% | 77% | 75% | 72% |
| 9   | 96%  | 92% | 89% | 86% | 84% | 81% | 79% | 76% | 74% | 71% |
| 8.5 | 94%  | 91% | 88% | 85% | 82% | 80% | 77% | 75% | 72% | 69% |
| 8   | 92%  | 89% | 86% | 84% | 81% | 79% | 76% | 74% | 71% | 68% |
| 7.5 | 91%  | 88% | 85% | 82% | 80% | 77% | 75% | 72% | 69% | 67% |
| 7   | 89%  | 86% | 84% | 81% | 79% | 76% | 74% | 71% | 68% | 65% |
| 6.5 | 88%  | 85% | 82% | 80% | 77% | 75% | 72% | 69% | 67% | 64% |

### Progression Example:

Say you just finished the following Intensity Day Workout:

*Week One, Intensity Day:*

Workout Performance: 405x3@9

x3@9 on RPE Chart: 89%

e1RM: 405 / .89 = 455

Now, you want to calculate a goal weight for next Intensity Day:

*Week Two, Intensity Day:*

Prescription: x2@9

x2@9 on RPE Chart: 92%

To Tie e1RM:  $455 * .92 = 418.6$

Next Workout Goal: 420x2@9

*If you get 420x2@9, or better, you know you set a PR because 420 is more than 418.6.*

### The Stalling Protocol:

| PIP Stalling Protocol |                                                                                       |
|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Phase 1               |                                                                                       |
| Definition            | Failing to get at least one rep on intensity day                                      |
| Protocol              | Move to Phase 2                                                                       |
|                       | Deload by doing no back-offs for the first week in Phase 2                            |
| Note                  | If you fail to get the minimum reps on any other day, just reset 15% on that movement |
| Phase 2               |                                                                                       |
| Definition            | Failing to get an e1RM PR at least once in any three week training cycle              |
| Protocol              | Move to Phase 3                                                                       |
|                       | Deload by doing no back-offs for the first week in Phase 3                            |
| Phase 3               |                                                                                       |
| Definition            | Failing to get an e1RM PR at least once in three training cycles (9 weeks)            |
| Protocol              | Move to Advanced Programming                                                          |
|                       | Deload One Week                                                                       |

## Program Execution:

### Starting Weights

#### Volume Day

For Volume Day, I'd recommend starting at approximately 80% of your one rep max, a weight that you can get for about eight reps, or simply using your last successful six rep workout weight from the PNP3.

Because several of the movements may be new to you, you're just going to have to work up to an appropriate weight during the first week. You're going to want to shoot for something you can do for six reps at an RPE of 8-9 on these movements. We want to start slightly on the conservative side. The weights will quickly autoregulate due to our progression protocol anyways.

#### Recovery Day

For Recovery Day, because the movements may be new to you, use the same "work up" process. I'd recommend shooting for eight reps at RPE 8-9. If these movements are not new to you, simply use about 75% or a weight that you can get for about ten reps.

#### Intensity Day

On Intensity Day, you're going to want to start with about 85%, a weight that you can do for five reps, or simply use your last successful three rep workout from the PNP3. Every intermediate should know their approximate ability on the competition lifts. There should be no need for work-ups.

### Rest Periods

Again, I'd recommend keeping your rest periods reasonable. Do not go beyond 3-5 minutes or so. If your workouts start to take longer than three hours, I'd recommend establishing time limits per exercise. Even if you don't reach your desired fatigue, you'd still move on from the exercise. Depending on what phase you're in, this is going to give you a total of forty-five to sixty minutes for each exercise including all breaks, warm-ups, plate changing, and whatever else you need to do between sets.

### Workout Execution:

#### *PIP1 Workout Protocol*

You're simply going to use the following protocol which is the same as PNP3.

#### Warm-Up Protocol:

*Note: All %s Listed Are of Your Top Set*

Bar x Sets x Reps till warm

30% x 5 Reps

50% x 5 reps

70% x 3 Reps

80% x 2 Rep  
90% x 1 Rep  
100% x Top Set

#### Back-Off Sets:

- 1) Subtract the indicated percentage
- 2) Repeat sets at the lowered weight using the same reps you got on your top set
- 3) Stop once the back-off weight reaches the same RPE as your top set (or within 0.5 RPE)

#### PIP1 Example Workout:

45 x 10 x 3  
95 x 5  
155 x 5  
220 x 3  
255 x 1  
285 x 1  
315 x 6 @ 9, 6-9% load drop (aim for 7.5%), Initial Top Set  
290 x 6 @ 7  
290 x 6 @ 8  
**290 x 6 @ 9, STOP HERE! Fatigue reached**

#### PIP2 and PIP3

In PIP1, and all throughout the PNP, you know your top sets before you ever get to the gym. However, that is not the case in PIP2 and PIP3. PIP2 and PIP3 are fully autoregulated and you won't necessarily know for sure what your top set is going to be before you get to the gym.

In order to pick weights that will ensure progress, while leaving us room to autoregulate on any given day, we need to incorporate two concepts: 1) the estimated one rep max (e1RM) and 2) "work-up sets".

#### E1RM: Estimated One Rep Max

Using the RPE Chart, we garner an estimation of our one rep max fairly easily. All we need to know is our weight, the reps we did, and the RPE we performed those reps at.

|     | 1    | 2   | 3   | 4   | 5   | 6   | 7   | 8   | 9   | 10  |
|-----|------|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|
| 10  | 100% | 96% | 92% | 89% | 86% | 84% | 81% | 79% | 76% | 74% |
| 9.5 | 98%  | 94% | 91% | 88% | 85% | 82% | 80% | 77% | 75% | 72% |
| 9   | 96%  | 92% | 89% | 86% | 84% | 81% | 79% | 76% | 74% | 71% |
| 8.5 | 94%  | 91% | 88% | 85% | 82% | 80% | 77% | 75% | 72% | 69% |
| 8   | 92%  | 89% | 86% | 84% | 81% | 79% | 76% | 74% | 71% | 68% |
| 7.5 | 91%  | 88% | 85% | 82% | 80% | 77% | 75% | 72% | 69% | 67% |
| 7   | 89%  | 86% | 84% | 81% | 79% | 76% | 74% | 71% | 68% | 65% |
| 6.5 | 88%  | 85% | 82% | 80% | 77% | 75% | 72% | 69% | 67% | 64% |

For example, let's say we squatted 405x3@9 on Intensity Day during Week One of Phase Two. We know that next week, on Intensity Day, we're supposed to shoot for x2@9. How can we make sure that we pick a weight that will result in a reasonable PR if we successfully complete the set?

It isn't too complicated:

- 1) Look up x3@9 on the RPE Chart: ~89%
- 2) Look up x2@9 on the RPE Chart: ~92%
- 3) Calculate e1RM from our last workout:  $(405/.89) = 455$
- 4) Calculate what we'd need to tie 455 using x2@9:  $(455*.92) = 418.6$
- 5) Add 1-5lbs/0.5-2.5kg to select a goal weight: 420
- 6) Our next workout target is 420x2@9

Using this method, we can ensure that our e1RM is constantly climbing up a few pounds here and there. We won't always get PRs every single week, but that is the point of autoregulation. Now that we've handled weight selection, let's talk about how to deal with the fact that everyone has good days and bad days.

### Work-Up Sets

Because we're autoregulating our top sets, we need a few "work-up" sets to gauge our performance for the day. *Remember, RPE is not based on how YOU feel. RPE is based on how the WEIGHTS move.* If you're lifting weights fast, but you feel like crap, that doesn't matter. What matters is how many reps you feel you have left in the tank based on bar speed.

For PIP2 and PIP3, we change our warm-up protocol to include these work-up sets. Using the example above, we're going to assume our goal is 420x2@9.

### Example Workout with Work Ups:

Bar x Sets x Reps to get warm

125 x 5 (30%)

210 x 5 (50%)

295 x 3 (70%)

335 x 1 (80%)

380 x 2 (90%)

400 x 2 (95%)

420 x 2 (100%)

As you can see, we do two "work-up" sets at 90% and 95% using the same reps as our top set for the day. Again, this allows us to "gauge" how we're performing that day in order to use autoregulation. Here is how this might play out in terms of actual autoregulation.

### On An Average Day:

335x1@6

380x2@7, as expected

400x2@8, as expected

420x2@9, Small PR

Great job picking the weight! Ideally, this will be the most common result you get.

### *On A Bad Day:*

335x1@6.5

380x2@8, harder than expected, might want to lower your expectations

400x2@9, Stop Here

Well, you didn't get near your goal weight, but we all have bad days. That's okay. This is the whole point of autoregulation.

### *On a Good Day:*

335x1@6

380x2@6, easier than expected

400x2@7, way easier than expected, up your top set!

435x2@9, HUGE PR

You cannot count on good days to happen, but they do come along every so often. With autoregulation and work-up sets, you can pounce on the opportunity when it shows itself. Again, this is the point of autoregulation in a nut shell.

### *What if I get the wrong RPE?*

One final issue that I want to address with RPE is that of overshooting and undershooting. In other words, if you're prescribed @9, and you go to @8 what should you do? What about @10?

#### Undershooting

If you undershoot a full point on the RPE scale, you should do another set. That is, if your top set is only @8, do another top set with a bit more weight. If you get within half a point, that's acceptable. In other words, if your top set is @8.5, don't do another set.

#### Overshooting

If you accidentally go to @9.5 or @10, you definitely need to stop there. If you are in the middle of a set, *I would always recommend trying to get the prescribed reps unless your last rep was @10.* I don't want you to purposefully fail. I do want you to try and get your reps and then measure RPE after the fact.

#### Back-Off Sets When You Get the RPE Wrong

If you undershoot or overshoot, the major implications are on your back-off sets. For your back-off calculations, use the weight that you think you should have used to get your original prescribed RPE. While you can bust out the calculator and figure everything out, I'd recommend just using common sense.

Let's say you were supposed to get @9 for your top set. If you got 405x3@8.5, take your %s off of 410-415 or so instead. Do back-offs until @9 as you were prescribed.

If you got 405x3@10, you're going to need to make a bit more substantial adjustment. In this case, you'd probably want to base things off around 385-390 or so.

Again, you can calculate all of this precisely with the RPE Chart but you should be able to get close enough just using your best guess.

### **GPP, Conditioning and Mobility:**

This is going to remain exactly the same as it was in PNP. The only exception is the fact that, during PIP3, you will have different time limits on GPP during different weeks as well as different amounts of required sprints.

#### **GPP, Conditioning, Mobility -- Phase Comparison**

*PNP1, PNP2, PNP3:* 7 minutes for GPP movements, 7 sprints

*PIP1 and PIP2:* 7 minutes for GPP movements, 7 Sprints

*PIP3:*

Week 1: 10 minutes for GPP Movements, 10 sprints

Week 2: 5 minutes for GPP Movements, 5 sprints

Week 3: 7 minutes for GPP Movements, 7 sprints

### **PIP1 vs. PIP2 vs. PIP3**

While you can obviously look at the charts above to see what is required in each phase of the program, I want to provide a text explanation as well to ensure your understanding.

#### ***PIP1***

In PIP 1, you're doing the same thing every week. Nothing changes from week to week. You're still using rep ranges on your top sets.

#### **Monday: Volume/Strength Day**

2-Count Pause Squats: x4-6@9, 6-9% Load Drop

2-Count Pause Bench: x4-6@9, 6-9% Load Drop

2" Deficit Deadlift: x4-6@9, 4-6% Load Drop

Closegrip Bench: x4-6@9, 4-6% Load Drop

#### **Wednesday: Recovery/Hypertrophy Day**

Front Squat: x6-8@8, 4-6% Repeat

Incline Bench: x6-8@8, 4-6% Repeat

#### **Friday: Intensity/Power Day**

Competition Squat: x1-3@9, 2-3% Load Drop

Competition Bench: x1-3@9, 4-6% Load Drop

Competition Deadlift: x1-3@9, 2-3% Load Drop

#### ***PIP2***

In PIP2, things are shaken up fairly significantly. We no longer use rep ranges and we move to fully autoregulation of intensity. We now use work-up sets to determine our top weights each day rather than adding an sort of linear increment.

You also begin to train four times per week and you also move to a three week training cycle.

### Three Week Cycle

For the three week cycle, you're simply going to drop a rep each week.

For volume movements, you'll do 6 reps in Week 1, 5 reps in Week 2, and 4 reps in Week 3. For hypertrophy movements, you'll do 8 reps in Week 1, 7 reps in Week 2, and 6 reps in Week 3. For intensity movements, you'll do 3 reps in Week 1, 2 reps in Week 2, and 1 rep in Week 3.

### Four Times Per Week Training Split

Instead of a single day dedicated to volume and intensity, we now have two training sessions dedicated to each.

#### *Volume Workouts*

The Monday/Tuesday volume workouts look like this:

##### *Monday: Volume Day #1*

2-Count Pause Squat: x6/5/4 @ 9, 6-9% Load Drop

2-Count Pause Bench: x6/5/4 @ 9, 6-9% Load Drop

Incline Bench: x8/7/6 @ 9, 4-6% Repeat

##### *Tuesday: Volume Day #2*

2" Deficit Deadlift: x6/5/4 @ 9, 6-9% Load Drop

Closegrip Bench: x6/5/4 @ 9, 6-9% Load Drop

Front Squat: x8/7/6 @ 9, 4-6% Repeat

#### *Intensity Workouts:*

The Friday/Saturday intensity workouts look like this:

##### *Friday: Intensity Day #1*

Competition Squat: x3/2/1 @ 9, 2-3% Load Drop

Competition Bench: x3/2/1 @ 9, 2-3% Load Drop

Overhead Press: x8/7/6 @ 8, 4-6% Repeat

##### *Saturday: Intensity Day #2*

Competition Deadlift: x3/2/1 @ 9, 2-3% Load Drop

Touch and Go Bench: x3/2/1 @ 9, 2-3% Load Drop

2" Deficit Stiff-Legged Deadlift: x8/7/6 @ 8, 4-6% Repeat

### PIP3

The only real difference between PIP3 and PIP2 is the fact that volume begins to wave in PIP3 from week to week.

### Week 1 is Volume Week

In PIP3, during Week 1, you'll do all the same movements as PIP2, but you'll do all of them for 6-9% fatigue even on intensity day and even with your hypertrophy movements. This is because Week 1 of PIP3 is "Volume Week" and it is designed to beat you up. You'll average 45% fatigue for upper and lower body, each.

### Week 2 is Recovery Week

In Week 2, you won't do ANY hypertrophy movements at all. Volume movements will drop from 6-9% to 4-6%. Intensity movements will drop back to their usual 2-3%. The reason volume is reduced so drastically during this week is that Week 2 is "Recovery Week". You'll average 15% fatigue for upper and lower body, each.

### Week 3 is Intensity Week

In Week 3, you'll return to the exact same program that you used during Week 3 of PIP2. This is the week where you will hit heavy singles and hopefully nail a PR. Volume movements will be done for 6-9% fatigue, hypertrophy movements will be done for 4-6% fatigue, and intensity movements will be done for 2-3% fatigue. The reason for this is that we want to have a medium volume week so that we can be sure we go into our next cycle fresh. For Week 3, you'll average 30% fatigue for upper and lower body, each.

## Program Analysis and Explanation

### Planning

In terms of peaking for a meet, all of the intermediate phases are explicitly designed to peak your strength going into the weekend. They're constructed for competition purposes. As such, I encourage you to compete early and often.

### Competing During PIP1

For PIP1, you have two options. If you're feeling good in general, simply skip your Friday workout and compete in the meet. That's it. Return to normal training the next Monday. Your weights might be a bit down at first, but that is the point of autoregulation. You'll quickly recover. Now, if you're feeling beat up, I'd recommend that you deload the week going into the meet. To do this, simply perform all of your usual workouts but do not do ANY back-off sets or repeats. Simply work up to your initial top sets and nothing more.

| Phase 1, Peaking |                |             |              |     |     |         |     |
|------------------|----------------|-------------|--------------|-----|-----|---------|-----|
| Weeks Out        | Mon            | Tue         | Wed          | Thu | Fri | Sat     | Sun |
| 1                | Train Normally |             |              |     |     |         |     |
| Meet             | No Back-Offs   | No GPP/HIIT | No Back-Offs | Off | Off | Compete |     |

### Competing During PIP2

For PIP2, my recommendations are very similar. However, because PIP2 introduces the element of a three week cycle, you're going to want to time your meet so that it occurs during Week Three – the week where you're supposed to go for heavy singles anyways. If you're feeling beat-up, I'd highly recommend deloading during that week. If you feel good, I'd just perform as usual and, again, skip your Friday/Saturday workouts and simply do a meet that Saturday instead.

| Phase 2, Peaking |                                     |              |             |               |     |         |     |
|------------------|-------------------------------------|--------------|-------------|---------------|-----|---------|-----|
| Weeks Out        | Mon                                 | Tue          | Wed         | Thu           | Fri | Sat     | Sun |
| 2                | Perform Week 1 of Phase 2 as normal |              |             |               |     |         |     |
| 1                | Perform Week 2 of Phase 2 as normal |              |             |               |     |         |     |
| Meet             | No Back-Offs                        | No Back-Offs | No GPP/HIIT | Warm-ups Only | Off | Compete |     |

### Competing During PIP3

With Phase Three, my recommendations become a little more complicated. You want to time your three week cycle to end with the meet one week away. In other words, you'd start a new three week cycle once you are four weeks out. During meet week, you're going to peak using the following template:

### PIP3 Meet Week Protocol

Monday: Work up to a single at ~87.5-92.5% of your best e1RM on the squat, bench and deadlift.

Wednesday: Work up to a single at ~80% of your best e1RM on the squat, bench, and deadlift.

Saturday: Compete

| Phase 3, Peaking |                                     |     |               |     |     |         |             |
|------------------|-------------------------------------|-----|---------------|-----|-----|---------|-------------|
| Weeks Out        | Mon                                 | Tue | Wed           | Thu | Fri | Sat     | Sun         |
| 3                | Perform Week 1 of Phase 3 as normal |     |               |     |     |         |             |
| 2                | Perform Week 2 of Phase 3 as normal |     |               |     |     |         |             |
| 1                | Perform Week 3 of Phase 1 as normal |     |               |     |     |         | No GPP/HIIT |
| Meet             | Openers                             | Off | Warm-Ups Only | Off | Off | Compete | Off         |

### Periodization

Remember, the hallmark of the intermediate trainee is that they need programmatic variety, but they do not need periods of specific emphasis on different muscular qualities. That said, as we've also pointed out, training advancement is a continuum. The more advanced an intermediate trainee becomes, the more and more elements of periodization they're going to need.

#### PIP1 Periodization

As such, you'll notice in PIP1 that, unlike the PNP, each day during the training week is oriented towards a specific quality. In fact, this is called [Daily Undulating Periodization](#) (DUP). DUP, in an oversimplified nutshell, emphasizes a different training quality every single training session hence the name. The effectiveness of DUP is backed up by ample scientific literature thanks to the diligent research of [Dr. Mike Zourdos](#).

Volume Day is dedicated towards general strength and technique; Recovery Day uses more general exercises with a longer range of motion and is aimed primarily at hypertrophy; and, Intensity Day uses extremely heavy poundages on the compound movements and is aimed explicitly at maximal strength.

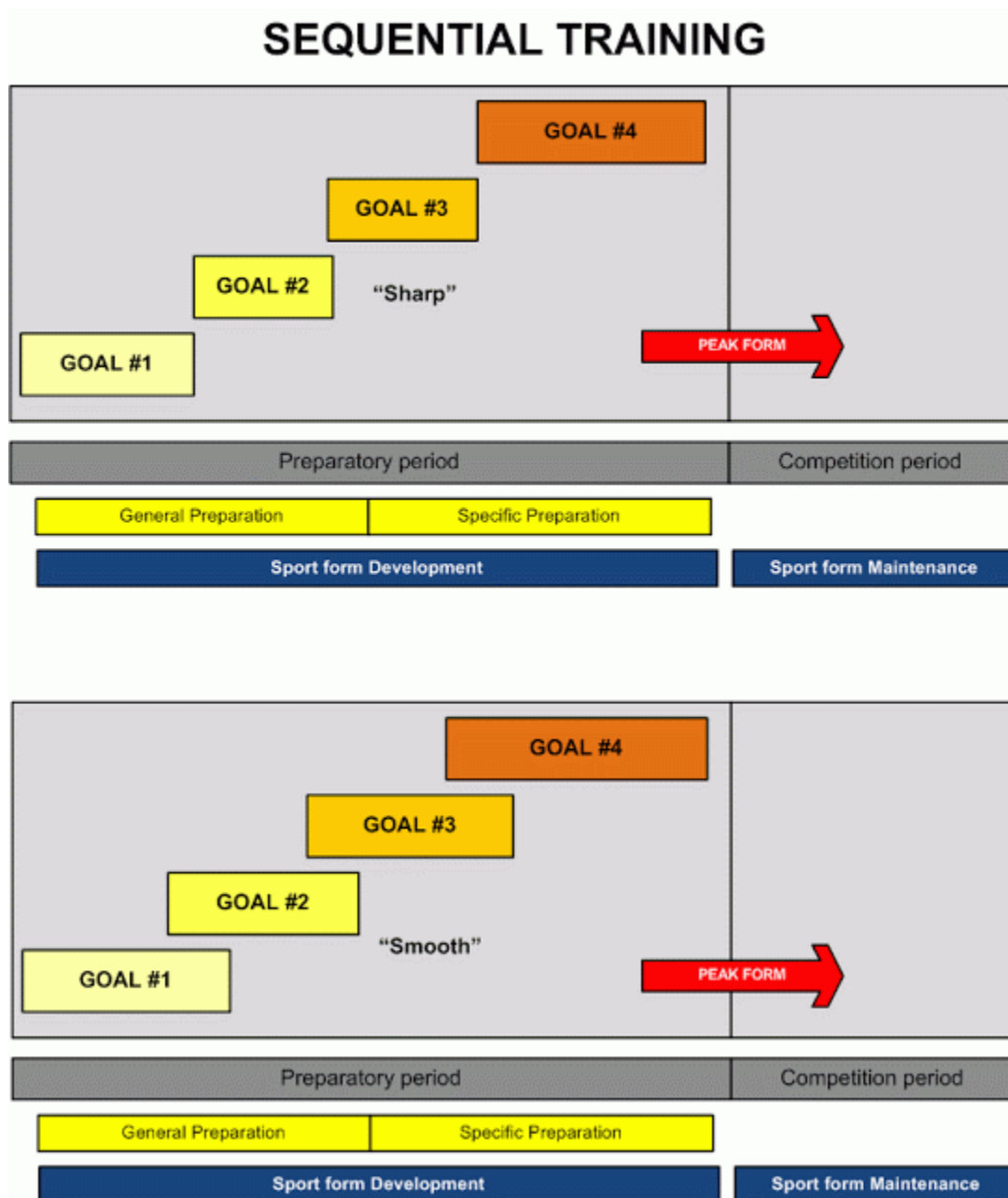
We're not dedicating entire periods to each quality in terms of weeks, but we are doing so, to some extent, in terms of each single day in the week. As a trainee becomes more advanced, the periods of emphasis become longer and more clearly divided.

#### Periodization in PIP2 and PIP3

In PIP2 and PIP3, we start to bring in elements of linear periodization. Linear Periodization is the first type of programming that a trainee who has just crossed into the advanced stages will use. Linear Periodization involves slowly decreasing the reps over a period of weeks. Usually, you'll spend a few weeks doing sets of 8, a few weeks doing sets of 5, a few weeks doing sets of 3, a few weeks doing 2s, and, finally, a week or two of singles to prep for a competition.

Because we aren't advanced trainees, we stick with a simple three week cycle. Remember, training advancement is a continuum. As such, Volume Day moves down from 6s, to 5s, and finally to 4s at the end of the three week cycle. Intensity Day moves down from 3s, to 2s, and finally to singles.

So, while more advanced forms of periodization aren't necessary for intermediate trainees, you can see that, as the trainee becomes more advanced, we've slowly brought in elements of these advanced concepts. Just as we slowly brought in programmatic variety and autoregulation in the novice phase to make the transition to intermediate training easier, this process sets the groundwork for a smooth, easy transition to advanced styles of training.



The "Sharp" organization might represent the highly advanced athlete whereas the "Smooth" organization might represent that of someone just transitioning into advanced style training. Think of our "advanced" intermediate trainee as nearer towards this end of the continuum.

photo: pureperformance.net

## Programming

### PIP1

Perhaps the most interesting element of the entire Intermediate Program comes down to its programmatic structure.

#### Rehashing “Light Day”

In PNP2, we introduce a light day in the middle of the week. As a reminder, this allows for more recovery time while still allowing us to push the volume stimulus up on our heavy days. Well, the issue is that the intermediate trainee eventually needs even more volume and 72 hours of recovery simply doesn't cut it anymore. They start to need 96 hours or more.

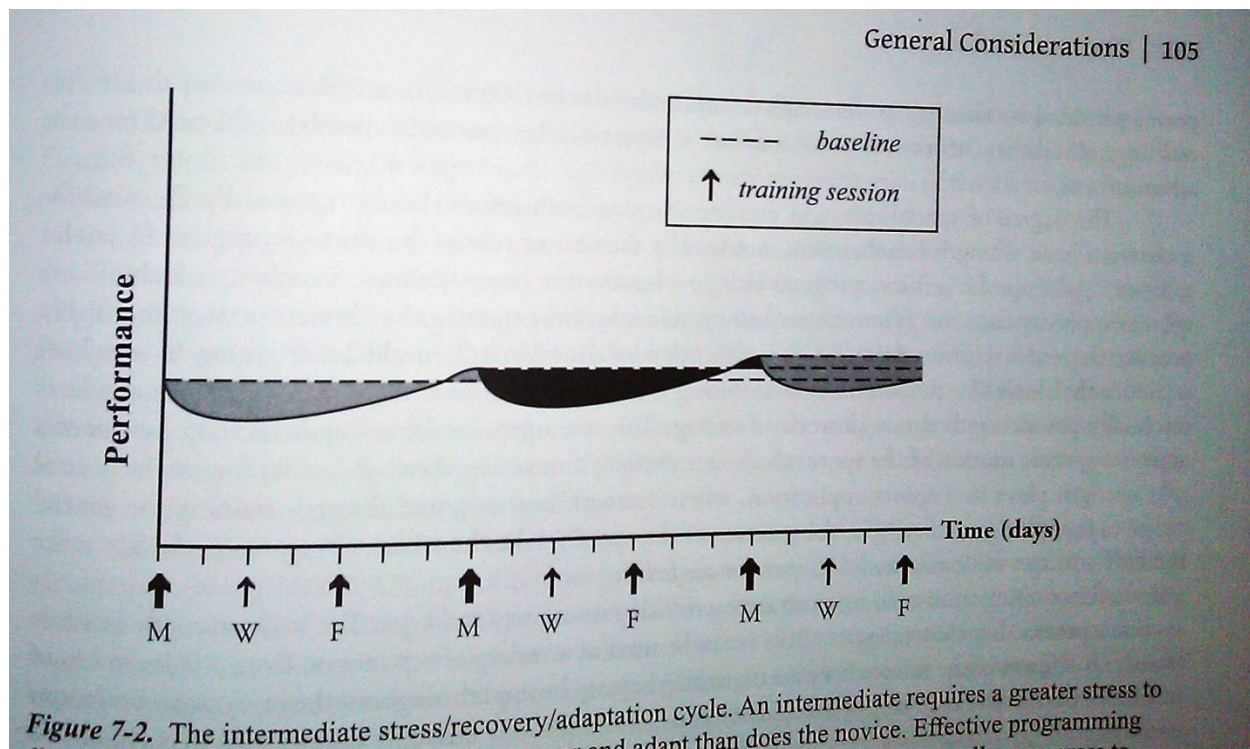


Photo: [Practical Programming 3rd Ed](#), Mark Rippetoe, 2014.

We have two options here. We can elongate our training week beyond seven days and decrease frequency to increase the length of the novice phase or we can manipulate volume and intensity to maintain the weekly training organization. We opt for the latter. Here's how we do that.

#### Hard – Light – Medium

We know that the intermediate trainee needs more volume than he was getting from the novice heavy days otherwise he wouldn't have stalled. However, we also know that further increasing the volume will make the recovery from Friday's workout to Monday's workout impossible. As such, what we actually do is increase volume on Monday while decreasing volume on Friday. This gives us a “hard – light – medium” structure in terms of volume.

For example, consider the total fatigue percentages in PIP1:

| PIP1 Daily Fatigue |           |
|--------------------|-----------|
| Day                | Fatigue % |
| <i>Monday</i>      | 10-15%    |
| <i>Wednesday</i>   | 4-6%      |
| <i>Friday</i>      | 4-6%      |

#### Volume – Recovery – Intensity

To enhance the training effect even further, we take advantage of the lowered volume on Fridays by increasing the intensity. The increased intensity helps promote neural adaptations, improves technique with heavy weights, and stimulates a host of other adaptive benefits related to maximal strength.

By using movement varieties on our training days, we can then mold the program, in terms of intensity, into a “medium – light – heavy” structure. By doing so, each training day in the week complements the others.

For example, consider the squat movement selection and rep ranges:

| PIP1 Movement Selection    |                    |             |
|----------------------------|--------------------|-------------|
| Exercise                   | Relative Intensity | Rep Range   |
| <i>2-Count Pause Squat</i> | <i>Medium</i>      | 4-6, medium |
| <i>Front Squat</i>         | <i>Lightest</i>    | 6-8, high   |
| <i>Competition Squat</i>   | <i>Heaviest</i>    | 1-3, low    |

#### Volume Day

For Monday, we use high volume, but we also use exercises that reduce the amount of absolute intensity we can use such as long paused squats and long paused benches. In addition to the exercise selection, we use higher rep ranges to reduce relative intensity as well. This allows us to perform a high volume workout which drives progress for the Friday Intensity workout. However, because of the reduction in intensity, we can still recover despite the higher volumes. The medium rep range allows us to focus on strength and technique.

#### Recovery Day

Wednesday uses both light variations and small volume. This allows us to get in a workout that prevents detraining without significantly disrupting recovery from Monday’s volume day. We also use movements that are more general and have longer ranges of motion to promote hypertrophy.

### Intensity Day

By the time Friday rolls around, we're primed for a PR. Instead of doing another hard volume session making it impossible to recover for the next Monday, we simply hit VERY heavy weights and keep the volume to a moderate level. This allows us to get a great training effect from the intensity without pushing the volume so hard that we cannot recover by the end of the weekend. This is the "Power" day inside of DUP.

### PIP1 Summary

In totality, and ideally, this organization allows for weekly progress. Not only do we mimic "stress-recovery-adaptation" with our volume structure, but we also get a great variety of programmatic intensity through our exercise selection and rep schemes. This program blends the stress-recovery-adaptation structure of the [Texas Method](#) with the "medium-light-heavy" programs designed by [Bill Starr](#) as well as elements of [Mike Zourdos' Daily Undulating Periodization](#). Frankly, for the early intermediate, I think this is about as good as it gets.

### PIP2

With PIP2, our challenge is again to increase the volume whilst still allowing for full recovery.

#### Why We Increase Frequency in PIP2

By this time, in my experience and in my opinion, performing all the necessary volume in a single training session isn't practical. As such, we finally move on to a four times per week training structure. Volume day is split into two separate days and so is intensity day.

By reducing the amount of volume stimulus we receive in each single training day, we can increase total volume without significantly increasing recovery demands. At the same time, by this point, we're well-conditioned enough that we don't need to resort to puny volumes to make this happen. Both of our volume days remain substantial. This ensures we receive an optimal adaptive stimulus from each workout. This is in stark contrast to, say, trying to split a 5x5 program into many 1x5 workouts.

#### Introducing Weekly Variation

Additionally, to reflect the progressive nature of training advancement, we start to operate on a three week cycle. While there isn't substantial variation in volume from week to week, there is substantial variation in intensity. The more advanced the trainee becomes, the more programmatic variety they need.

The fatigue from week to week will remain relatively stable, but the weights constantly get heavier. This is a great way to introduce the aforementioned weekly intensity variation into an intermediate's program.

### PIP3

With PIP3, we start to straddle the line between an advanced program and intermediate program.

#### Introducing Weekly Volume Variation

To reflect the still furthered advancement of our trainee, in addition to the variety in weekly intensity that we introduced in PIP2, we also introduce significant variety in volume.

In fact, if you look closely, you'll notice that our three week cycle actually reflects the same exact structure that is found inside of each week in PIP1. That is, Week One of PIP3 is an entire week dedicated to volume; Week Two of PIP3 is an entire week dedicated to recovery; and, Week Three of PIP3 is an entire week dedicated to intensity. Week One is high volume, Week Two is low volume, and Week Three is medium volume.

### Understanding the Weekly Volume "Wave" in PIP3

The reason that we have to increase volume in Week One is the same reason we've increased the volume of our Monday workout in PIP1. The total weekly volume is no longer enough to drive adaptation. Therefore, we must increase the total weekly volume.

That said, we also know this won't allow full recovery at the end of the week because we're already pushing recovery limits. By introducing a light week directly following the extremely tough high volume week, we allow for recovery without detraining.

Then, when the third week rolls around, we perform a medium volume week and demonstrate our new adaptation while allowing any fatigue that has accumulated to dissipate before starting a new cycle. As I said above, this is essentially the Texas Method stretched out over three weeks instead of stretched out over three training days.

### PIP3 Programming Summary

By PIP3, our intermediate trainee is using full autoregulation, elements of linear periodization and daily undulating periodization, and they've got significant programmatic variety both inside each training week and between training weeks. The only thing that separates this program from a truly advanced program is the length of the periodization. As such, this is the perfect point from which to transition into truly advanced programmatic structures lasting 8-16 weeks such as block periodization, linear periodization, and others.

| Theoretical Examples |                               |  |                               |  |
|----------------------|-------------------------------|--|-------------------------------|--|
| Novice               | Mesocycle 1                   |  | Mesocycle 2                   |  |
|                      | All Attributes                |  | All Attributes                |  |
|                      | Static                        |  | Static                        |  |
| Intermediate         | Mesocycle 1                   |  | Mesocycle 2                   |  |
|                      | All Attributes                |  | All Attributes                |  |
|                      | High Volume, Medium Intensity |  | Low Volume, Medium Intensity  |  |
| Advanced             | Mesocycle 1                   |  | Mesocycle 2                   |  |
|                      | Hypertrophy                   |  | Speed                         |  |
|                      | High Volume, Medium Intensity |  | Medium Volume, High Intensity |  |

PIP3 is actually somewhere between "Intermediate" and "Advanced" on this chart.

## Specificity

It should be noted that specificity actually decreases from PNP to PIP. On PIP, we increase the amount of general movements that we do and we also increase the amount of close variations.

## Diminishing Marginal Returns

The reason for this is fairly simple. In the novice phase of training advancement, you're still learning basic competencies in terms of your ability to even perform the lifts correctly. The technical gains you make from frequent practice alone outweigh any considerations in terms of diminishing marginal benefits. However, in the intermediate stage, once you've got a better handle on technique, repeating the same stimulus over and over loses some of its effectiveness.

We know that the carryover from doing competition style squats for reps to improving our competition style squat 1RM is better than doing, say, paused squats for reps. However, the law of accommodation tells us that the more often you are exposed to a given stimulus, the less the adaptive response will be. That is, the tanner you get, the less the sunlight is going to affect you.

Likewise, if you're already performing the competition squat during the week, a second session might only give 80% carryover and a third session might produce 60% carryover. The benefits diminish. Now, a variation such as, say, Front Squats might only give 65% carryover, but that is still higher than adding a third competition squat session. So, at some point, due to these diminishing marginal benefits, we want to include variety.

## Exercise Selection Matters

That point is in the intermediate phase. During your intermediate training, you'll determine which exercises work best for you. The exercises on this program are specifically selected for the absolute intensities they produce as well as the fact that they address the most common weaknesses of raw lifters. A full discussion on exercise selection will have to wait for further editions of this book. I consider it an advanced concept and I will wait until discussing advanced programming to examine it in depth.

However, that said, it should go without saying that optimizing any programming for a particular individual cannot be done without analysis of their particular weaknesses. Without exercise selection specific to those weaknesses, the program cannot be optimal. I've done my best to pick exercises here that would benefit the greatest amount of people, but there is only so much you can do with a cookie cutter program. If you want a personalized, customized program, please [email me to discuss my coaching services](#).

## PIP Is Still Highly Specific

All this said, you should note that PIP retains much of the specificity of PNP:

1. You will find no bodybuilding assistance whatsoever in the main workouts.
2. You will find no weird variations that don't involve barbells.
3. You will find that most of the volume comes from close variations of the competition movements and the competition movements themselves.

4. You will find that, throughout the week, exercises are always performed in the order they would be performed at a competition.
5. You will find that HEAVY work is performed on the competition style movements.
6. You will find that every aspect of these programs is specifically designed to accommodate the needs of a powerlifter.

This is no general strength program; this is no “powerbuilding” program; this is a powerlifting program through and through.

## Overload

### *PIP1*

PIP1 uses the same simultaneous double progression found in PNP. For reasons argued there, I still contend that this is the best “linear” method of progress. As such, I find it much more appropriate than simply adding a fixed amount of weight to the bar as is typical of many other weekly intermediate programs.

### *PIP2 and PIP3*

Now, in PIP2 and PIP3, progressive overload is used, but it is not linear. Your rate of progress is determined through autoregulation. Even beyond setting PRs with e1RMs, the weights slowly increase due to the fact you’re dropping down a rep each week in terms of rep targets. As such, you’ll be exposed to heavier and heavier weights throughout each cycle regardless of whether you manage to set substantial e1RM PRs.

Basic progressive overload is tried and true. It works and works well.

## Fatigue Management

There are two variables that are manipulated here in terms of fatigue management: 1) overall programmatic structure and 2) the total amount of fatigue assigned through fatigue percentages.

### Overall Programmatic Structure

We’ve already covered a lot of the details of the programmatic structure elsewhere, but let’s recap.

As we transition from PNP, PIP1 incorporates a heavy-light-medium structure both in terms of volume and intensity. We do more volume on Monday while still recovering by the end of the week due to the fact that Friday is reduced to a medium volume day.

As we transition from PIP1 to PIP2, our volume day is split into two separate workouts and our training frequency increases to four times per week. It is easier to recover from smaller, but more frequent doses of volume even when the total dose is the same. We take advantage of this fact with our training frequency increase.

Now, as we transition to PIP3, we further manage fatigue by making use of high volume weeks, low volume weeks, and medium volume weeks. Because our volume days are no longer sufficient to drive progress, we resort to an extremely high volume week. Of course, we can't recover from that kind of volume inside of one week. So, in response, the following week is a recovery week with extremely reduced volume. This prevents detraining while still allowing for recovery. The third week is a medium week that allows any additional fatigue to dissipate while allowing us to shoot for the PRs that the high volume week has prepared us for. Essentially, we're stretching the organization of the Texas Method and PIP1 over three weeks instead of over three training days inside of one week.

#### Fatigue Percentages in Each Programmatic Phase

Now, some of you may have also noticed that total fatigue increases from phase to phase as well. We start using fatigue percents in PIP3. That data is included in the following table for further understanding:

*Total Weekly Fatigue Percent:*

| Total Weekly Fatigue |           |
|----------------------|-----------|
| Phase                | Fatigue % |
| PNP3                 | 12-23%    |
| PIP1                 | 18-27%    |
| PIP2                 | 24-36%    |
| PIP3, Week 1         | 36-54%    |
| PIP3, Week 2         | 12-18%    |
| PIP3, Week 3         | 24-36%    |

As you can see, each phase builds upon the last in terms of volume tolerance. Even from PNP1, you're being prepared to work up to the higher volumes in the later phases of PIP. This entire process prepares you to handle the workloads that are necessary at the advanced stages of programming.

#### Why Fatigue Slowly Increases

Additionally, the program is structured this way because, at each stage of training advancement, you need more volume. By building you gradually to these points, we make sure that you don't needlessly jump into a high volume program and short circuit your gains. We squeeze every fatigue range (nearly) dry before moving up to the next one. Through patience and persistence, you maximize each stage of advancement. This is in stark contrast to those who get greedy and try to do [Smolov](#) with a 315lbs/140kg squat.

## Individual Differences

### *PIP1 and Why It Isn't Fully Autoregulated*

You may notice that PIP1 doesn't incorporate full autoregulation in terms of intensity. This is for the same reason that full autoregulation of volume isn't incorporated until PNP3. My intention here is that each lifter gets some experience in the 1-3 rep range before they have to start basing their programming on the RPE of each set. If you've never lifted that heavy before, you won't have the experience to accurately rate RPE.

Additionally, we want to keep the progression protocol as simple as possible in the early going. By allowing lifters to fully work through the 1-3 rep range over a period of approximately linear increases, they get a great feel for what they're actually capable of. Far too often people are literally scared of these heavy weights. They don't know what they can actually do. Spending some time in a rep range pushing themselves, spending time being forced to lift heavier each time, will provide perspective and realism that will make their assessments of what they're actually capable of much more accurate. I don't want to provide people the ability to cop out with RPEs before they truly find out what they can do.

### *PIP2 and PIP3*

However, after Phase One, the kiddie gloves come off and the programs are fully autoregulated. To my knowledge, these are some of the only fully autoregulated early intermediate programs available on the internet. You have full autoregulation of both intensity AND volume by PIP2. This allows me to confidently state that the programmatic variables are, to the highest degree possible, optimal for each and every individual who goes through the entire process of building up to each phase.

### *Truly Optimal Programming Isn't Cookie Cutter*

Obviously, the biggest issue here is exercise selection, scheduling difficulties, and just all of the particulars that revolve around real human beings. I cannot optimize these factors for every single individual in a simple eBook. This requires intimate knowledge of a trainee. I have to actually know your situation to be able to help with that. There is enough information here that I hope you can figure out something on your own, but, of course, if you'd like a personalized, custom program, please email me at: [admin@PowerliftingToWin.com](mailto:admin@PowerliftingToWin.com) for more information on **PowerliftingToWin's** custom coaching packages.

## Chapter 9: Frequently Asked Questions

### Are Microplates Really Necessary?

Yes. If you don't purchase microplates or make your own, you are NOT doing the PowerliftingToWin programs. Period. I'm that adamant about this fact.

Look, without microplates, you're going to be trying to add, at a minimum, 15lbs/7.5kg to your lifts per week. That is 60lbs per month. That is NOT sustainable for more than a month or two at most and only for the rank beginner. Microplates allow you to make progress at a realistic pace and may extend your novice phase by three to six months.

If you care about an optimal rate of progression at all, you'll get microplates.

You can get them here:

- 1) [Microplates in Pounds](#)
- 2) [Microplates in KG](#)

### If I Fail A Workout, Can I Try Again?

If you fail a workout, and you're convinced, FOR SURE, that you can get it next time, you may try again up to one time before you reset. If you fail a second time, there is no negotiation whatsoever. You must reset. Again, you get ONE retry. That's it. Make it count if you're going to use it. I am not a fan of endless stalls and resets.

### How Should I Eat?

You should eat for YOUR particular goals. This program does NOT require a caloric surplus. Of course, it should go without saying that you'll make better progress if you attempt to gain some weight while doing the program. However, this is true of any program that you do.

If you'd like further guidance on nutrition, I'm going to direct you to the [PowerliftingToWin Nutrition Series](#).

### What Equipment Should I Use?

Assuming that you're here because you're interested in competing in Powerlifting, there are four pieces of equipment that I'd consider mandatory at some point or another: a [powerlifting belt](#), [powerlifting shoes](#), [knee sleeves](#), and [wrist wraps](#). I'd also include [chalk](#), but that isn't exactly a piece of equipment.

Here's the thing. If you're going to compete, you want your training to be as close to competition conditions as possible. It is only going to throw you off if you practice squatting out of a monolift when

the federation you compete in requires squats to be walked out of squat stands. The exact same thing holds true for wearing equipment like belts, knee sleeves, and wrist wraps. You will use a belt in competition and you must use a belt for this program.

For more information on the particulars of each type of equipment, including what you should look for when purchasing, how to use the equipment correctly, and my general recommendations for each item, please see the [PowerliftingToWin Equipment Series](#).

## What About My Technique?

There are a million potential questions about technique. Should you do high bar squats or low bar squats? Should you bench with a wide grip or a close grip? Should you use an arch in your back when you bench or should you use a flat back? How about sumo deadlifts versus conventional deadlifts? Help?

Frankly, these are all incredibly complicated questions to answer. As a powerlifter, your goal is to lift the most weight possible. You should use technique that allows you to safely do just that. If you want my personal recommendations on the most optimal form for powerlifting, please see the [PowerliftingToWin Technique Series](#).

## Where Can I Learn More About Programming?

The absolute best introductory text ever written on proper programming for lifting weights is Mark Rippetoe's [Practical Programming](#). If you want to learn the basics of proper programming including the actual physiology behind how muscle is built, how the adaptive process works, and the foundations of exercise science in general, I'd highly recommend the book. It is written so that the average lay person can easily understand and comprehend the text. Not only that, but the book contains more than 200 pages dedicated strictly to giving you programs from the novice level all the way to the advanced level. It is simply the best resource out there.

If you want to learn about autoregulation, there is only one source that I can recommend wholeheartedly: [Mike Tuchscherer's website](#) and the [Reactive Training Manual](#). Virtually everything I know about autoregulation came from either one of those resources. Tuchscherer is responsible for popularizing autoregulation amongst powerlifters. He is the real McCoy. Check out his information while it is still free.

If you'd like to learn more about overtraining and, in particular, why everything you've ever been told about CNS Fatigue is a complete myth, check out [Squat Every Day by Matt Perryman](#). If you're going to do being an autoregulated program, it is essential that you understand that how you "feel" isn't 100% correlated to how you perform. You need to realize that recovery isn't black and white. Recovery is a continuum like virtually every other training concept. You can actually set huge PRs while underrecovered and Perryman discusses why in his book.

Another great resource that I have referenced throughout this book is Mladen Jovanovic's [website](#). Now, Mladen's website is the exact opposite of Practical Programming. Mladen's first language is not English. While he does a fantastic job of providing EXTREMELY high level exercise science information, if you're a beginner or an intermediate, you'll be overwhelmed most likely. That said, if you want to start doing your own research on advanced concepts, and you don't want to pay \$50-100 for textbooks like [Supertraining](#), then I can recommend Mladen's website to you.

## **My Back/Knees/Wrists/Shoulders Hurt, What Should I Do?**

Understand that there is a difference between the typical aches and pains that a lifter experiences and true injuries. This difference is something that can only be gleaned through years of practical experience. Most aches and pains simply go away with sleep, food, and a bit of good old fashioned time. If you're not sure whether you're just achey or if you're actually hurt, always take the conservative route.

Injuries cannot, and SHOULD NOT, be diagnosed over the internet. The first thing you should do is stop asking people on the internet to do something irresponsible such as try to prescribe you with a rehabilitation protocol without examining you in person. After you do that, consult your physician.

## **Can I Make Exercise Substitutions?**

### **Changes to the Novice Program**

Yes and no. If you're doing the PNP, and you've made it to PNP2 or PNP3, you may consider making substitutions to the Wednesday workout.

While I personally believe these changes to be sub-optimal, I know that many of you truly believe some kind of overhead pressing is necessary for shoulder health. As such, you may change the 2-Count Pause Benches to Overhead Pressing or Incline Benching if you truly believe this will help your shoulders. There isn't a single other change I will approve to the PNP.

### **Changes to the Intermediate Program**

If you're doing PIP, exercise substitutions are actually recommended at some point, but I'd recommend that you run the template "as is" before changing anything first.

Again, as I said in the write-up, I picked the exercises based on their absolute intensity (how much you can use on them) and the fact they target most raw trainees personal weaknesses (the bottom of the movements). Now, if you are weak in the mid-range or at lockout, you'd want to adjust some of the exercises to account for these facts.

For example, if your bench mid-range needs work, instead of 2-Count Pause Bench, you might use Floor Press. If your lockout is lagging, you might use the 3-Board Press. These are overly simplistic examples,

but hopefully you get the point. Exercise selection needs to be optimized to the individual to be truly optimal. I cannot do that in a cookie program. It just isn't possible.

If you want help personalizing your PIP program, [please contact me for more information about my coaching services](#).

### **This Program Looks Boring. Can I Add More Stuff?**

No. If constantly setting PRs on the Big Three is boring to you, you're doing the wrong sport. Bodybuilding might be more to your liking.

### **What If I Miss Workouts?**

If you miss one workout, I'd recommend repeating your last successful workout. If you miss an entire week, I'd recommend resetting your weights 5-10%. They will quickly autoregulate back up to previous levels anyways. With a small reset, you can be sure you aren't trying to be too ambitious after your break.

If you miss something like a full month or more, I'd go back one full phase and use a full reset. For example, if you left for a long vacation and you were on PNP2, take your last successful PNP2 Workout, reset 20%, and start over with PNP 1. This will allow you to quickly regain all your lost progress and get you back on track ASAP.

### **If I'm Not Sure What Type of Trainee I Am, What Should I Do?**

If you're not sure if you're a novice, intermediate, or advanced trainee, I'd recommend just starting with PNP2. If you come from a bodybuilding background, you're still a novice to strength training anyway. You'll quickly move up through the phases and figure out where you really belong. If you try to start with an intermediate program, you may end up wasting months of faster progress on one of the novice phases all because you made an assumption that wasn't accurate. It is better to "prove" you're not a novice by stalling on the PNP a bit early than it is to get on an intermediate program and make progress at a slower than necessary rate.

### **I Am Not Interested in Powerlifting, Can I Still Do This Program?**

Sure, you can if you want to. That said, I don't see the point. EVERYTHING about this program is optimized specifically for the powerlifter. If your main goal is hypertrophy or athleticism, it doesn't make a lot of sense to do this program. The program, while addressing those things peripherally, focuses strictly on Powerlifting. If you do a program that isn't suited to your real goals, you shouldn't be surprised when the results are lacking.

## Chapter 10: Conclusion

### Final Thoughts

#### Moving Forward

Well my friends, there you have it: ProgrammingToWin. I certainly hope that this has been worth the wait. I believe this to be the finest work done thus far by [PowerliftingToWin](#). We'll only strive to get better from here.

I don't want to get too far ahead of myself, but, if this edition turns out to be as successful as I am anticipating, you can expect to see a series of similar free eBooks along the same lines: EatingToWin (nutrition), EquippedToWin (gear and equipment), ThinkingToWin (psychology), and TrainingToWin (technique). Of course, all of this in due time!

Eventually, I'd like to put out... PowerliftingToWin – The Powerlifter's Handbook. This would be a composite of all the topics discussed on PowerliftingToWin; the book would present a comprehensive, holistic take on nearly every relevant aspect of powerlifting performance. More importantly, the book would present a coherent strategy that combined all of these elements synergetically. But before I write a check that my ass can't cash, let's see how ProgrammingToWin performs.

Before the end, I do have some final thoughts for your consideration.

#### Start A Training Log!

If you decide to do either the PowerliftingToWin Novice Program (PNP) or the PowerliftingToWin Intermediate Program (PIP), I would be ecstatic to see you on board in the training log section of the [PowerliftingToWin forums](#). I give special attention to those on the forum who are running my programs. I do my best to see that those who use my programs succeed. Your personal journey will benefit dozens of other lifts who may be using the same program or who are considering doing so.

Beyond that, we always appreciate having hardworking, valuable new members! Who knows? Your training log may be the inspiration for further improvements and updates to the program. I hope to see you there.

#### If You Want More...

If you've been impressed with this content, I am quite sure that you will find [the informational archives at PowerliftingToWin.com](#) to be of the same caliber in terms of quality. If you're more of a visual learner, consider checking out the [PowerliftingToWin YouTube Channel](#) instead. Of course, if you've walked away from this reading feeling that you could benefit from working directly with me to optimize your nutrition and technique in addition to your programming, [please email me for more information regarding my coaching services](#).

#### My Goals for ProgrammingToWin

I truly hope that this has been a thoroughly comprehensive, thoroughly enjoyable look into the programming of the first two to three years of powerlifting training. I have endeavored to create a

resource that not only tells you what you should do, but why you should do it. My goal was that you walk away from this reading feeling entirely equipped to navigate the novice and intermediate phases of your training. My goal was that you would learn something from this book that would make you a better a lifter.

### **Please Show Your Support**

If I've succeeded in that goal, please consider showing your support by making a [small donation](#) to the continued development of [PowerliftingToWin](#).



If you're not in a financial position to do so, I completely understand. If you'd still like to show support, consider sharing this content with your lifting friends. As I said in the Foreword, there is NOTHING better for [PowerliftingToWin](#) than having more people who know what it is! Join us on [Facebook](#) or [YouTube](#) and help share the word!

Together, I hope we can create the best powerlifting community internet. I believe we're already well on our way. Time will tell.

*Have a nice day my friends,*

**Izzy Narvaez**

**[www.PowerliftingToWin.com](http://www.PowerliftingToWin.com)**



# PROGRAMMING TO WIN



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